

GRAMDAN For GRAM-SWARAJ

Va-19

गांधी सेवा संघ प्रकाशन

ग्राम स्वराज प्रकाशन

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Vinoba
&

Jayaprakash Narayan -

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PREFACE

The object of this selection, containing extracts from speeches delivered (in Hindi) by Vinobaji and Shri Jayaprakash Narayan on Gramdan from time to time during the last two years, is to convey to the English-reading public the idea of Gramdan, its rationale, its philosophy and its role in India today. It cannot be gainsaid that of all public activities, programmes and movements afoot in the country, Gramdan is the most prominent, widespread and far-reaching. Whereas all others propose to carry out bits of reforms or changes here and there, Gramdan claims to bring about a total revolution in the country through the non-violent process. Gradually its appeal is catching the imagination of the people, specially in Bihar, as manifest by the growing response there. No less than 10,554 villages have joined Gramdan in Bihar and 20 blocks too. Not Gramdan alone, but *Prakhand-dan* (or Block-dan) is the moving spirit in Bihar today.

Of the several ideologies in vogue in the modern world, the two most outstanding are Communism and Sarvodaya, based on the teachings of Karl Marx and Gandhi. The others have either little content or are covered in these two. Both of these stand for the uplift of the down-trodden, are against the ~~status quo~~, seek to build a social order free from exploitation and coercion and envisage the withering away of the state. But the two also differ distinctly.

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PREFACE

About a hundred years ago, Marx called upon the labourers of the world to unite in order to cast off their chains. It was the most momentous call ever given in human history to bring about economic equality and social justice. Marx killed the time-old myth that poverty was God-willed and irrevocable. The success his doctrine achieved in Russia and China have inspired and stirred millions of people all over the globe. Nevertheless, it must be sadly acknowledged that not all chains have been got rid off by any group or groups of labourers in any part of the world. Looking from this distance of time, it can be said that perhaps the labourers, or anybody else for that matter, could not shake off their external chains unless they removed the inner one holding them tight, *viz.*, possessiveness, a disease which they share in common with one and all. If a factory worker or a landless labourer sticks to his ownership of work or labour and refuses to surrender it to society in larger human interest, it is futile to expect a factory owner or landlord to part with the ownership of his possessions. In fact, the very classification of society into 'heads' and 'hands' or 'haves' and 'have-nots' is unjust and misleading, because if the 'haves' are rich in material or financial resources which the 'have-nots' miserably lack, the 'have-nots' are equally rich in bodily and labour resources in which the 'haves' are hopelessly deficient. Thus at the root of all exploitation and serfdom is the spirit of ownership. This is why Gandhi insisted on his. Theory of Trusteeship which envisages the ownership of all kinds of wealth by community and its use by the individual as a trustee.

As against Communism, Sarvodaya gives the call, 'People of the world, unite and surrender your ownership to community and you will then loose your chains'. Through the Gramdan movement, Vinoba is trying to turn this idea into a definite and practical reality. He has started with land as land is the basic means of production and once Gramdan succeeds in abolishing individual (as also State) ownership of land, ownership in all other fields will easily fade away.

In order to attain this Gramdan consummation, all elements of society, the so-called 'haves' as also the 'have-nots', must come forward together and make a joint offering of their resources to the community. In other words, the means adopted to enact the new revolution must be peaceful and non-violent : firstly because, violence does not ultimately bring about a change in values, and secondly because, violent means will always be the preserve of the ruling minority (be it a democratic, socialistic or communistic or totalitarian state) and will never be within the reach of the lowliest and the last. This brings us to the second difference between Sarvodaya and Communism. While the former stresses on truthful, non-violent and fair means, the latter has no hesitation in resorting to any means whatsoever for reaching a goal.

The Sarvodaya movement, with Gramdan as its spear-head, seeks to attain the triple target—of wiping out inequalities, of generating people's self-reliant power, and of transforming individual virtues or assets like truth and non-possession and non-violence into social forces as

PREFACE

desired by the onward march of science—through the process of persuasion, consent and conversion, in which non-cooperation with injustice or evil is implied. It thus proposes to bring about such a revolution, from the bottom upwards, as will help produce a new society which, marked by economic equality and social justice, will have its first as also its ultimate reliance on non-violence and human values. It will then usher in a new age of real brotherhood of Man and Fatherhood of Truth.

But when ? Sarvodaya to be worth its salt must be effective here and now. A delay in its fulfilment will amount to its doom. Hence Vinoba's call for *TOOFAN* and his appeal to Bihar to turn it into a Gramdani Bihar within a year so (not later than Christmas 1967). These pages are an attempt to show how India's survival and growth are dependent on Gramdan and why Vinoba is so anxious to wipe out the curse of individual ownership of land (or of its sale and purchase).

Besides, these pages also illustrate, as beautifully pointed out by Shri Jayaprakash Babu, the role of Gramdan in solving our current problems, viz., poverty, unemployment, corruption, etc. Jayaprakashji speaks for all sane humanity when he says that dictatorship is no panacea for any ills. In fact, it is an evil never to be tolerated or allowed a quarter and must be resisted at all cost. Jayaprakash Babu's repeated warning that all official reconstruction programmes and orthodox constructive work cannot succeed without the foundation of Gramdan should be an eye-opener to all concerned.

In the end, I must confess my limitations in trans-

PREFACE

lation and failure to capture the warmth and beauty and depth of the original. The task becomes specially difficult—albeit more inspiring and charming—when one has to convey the thoughts of leaders of the eminence of Vinoba and Jayaprakash whose speeches are characterised not only by the passion of their faith but also by the wealth of their thought and penetrating insight and stirring appeal. If, however, these pages induce the reader to know more about Gramdan and go out into the field to have a taste of its impact on the Indian peasantry, my labours would be amply rewarded.

Allahabad,
27th September 1966.

Suresh^{ji}Ram

CONTENTS

Chapter	I. Gramdan for Gram-Swaraj	Vinoba	1—13
„	II. Gramdan and National Defence	Vinoba	14—21
„	III. Gramdan : A Continuous Process of Revolution	Vinoba	22—28
„	IV. A Picture of Sarvodaya Social Order	Vinoba	29—44
„	V. Need for a total Revolution	Vinoba	45—50
„	VI. Towards a Typhoon of Light	Vinoba	51—57
„	VII. Gram-Swaraj delayed is Gram-Swaraj denied	Vinoba	58—64
„	VIII. A New Experiment in Human History	Jayaprakash Narayan	65—70
„	IX. Gramdan and Democracy	Jayaprakash Narayan	71—78
„	X. Panchayati Raj and Village Development	Jayaprakash Narayan	79—84
„	XI. The Triple Programme	Jayaprakash Narayan	85—93
„	XII. Towards Non-violent Socialism	Jayaprakash Narayan	94—112

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I

Gramdan for Gram-swaraj

[*Vinoba*]

How our country won freedom is a long story. Swaraj did come, but in whose hands ? The only difference it made was that the seat of power was shifted from London to Delhi. But if water were five hundred miles away instead of five thousand miles, it cannot slake the thirst of a thirsty man.

The Call of the Thirsty

Before Swaraj, our disputes and cases were decided in London. First they went to the ordinary court, later the appeal was filed in the High Court of Bombay or Calcutta and thereafter in the Privy Council at London. Now after Swaraj, cases are finally disposed off at Delhi rather than at London. Yet the people feel that it has not solved any issue. At last it was decided to distribute power among the provinces. A constitution was framed demarcating the zones of the provinces and the centre. The effect of it was that water came nearer, at a distance of two to three hundred miles. But the thirst of the people is still not quenched. At long last it was felt that power should be divided among the districts.

This having been done, water was only fifty miles away. Yet there is no satisfaction. Why? Because water did not reach the mouth. Then they decided to set up Gram Panchayats. Thus power flowed down to the Panchayats.

Panchayat or Conflict ?

But how much power did the Panchayats get ? Only that much as was released by those above. Much of it was preserved by those of Delhi for themselves, some by those of the province, some by those of the district and the remaining little was handed over to the village Panchayats. This reminded me of a song of Tukaram. Therein he says that instead of finding devotion in God or attachment to the scriptures, one meets only 'Panchayat' everywhere, meaning quarrels and conflicts. Panchayat means place of conflict. In other words, the conflicts of Delhi are now dispersed all over the country. From Delhi to the state capital, on to the district and thereafter to the Panchayat. In short, the bitterness, rivalry and conflict of Delhi have been nationalised.

Thus Panchayats have led to more conflicts and differences and dissensions. The reason is that the rights conferred from above were very limited. There is no question of thinking or planning in terms of the whole village. The Panchayat has the authority to build roads, set up markets and a few other things, but none about the land. You can sell land or mortgage it without any reference to the village. One may think that people do not deserve and giving them complete powers will result in feuds and conflicts.

The elections held in Gram Panchayats are on the basis of party politics. This has carried 'party-ism' to every village. Recently they came from a village and told me that the Panchayat elections had created so much bitterness and bad blood that people did not want to see each other's face. This is a natural outcome when things are done in a half-hearted manner.

Ownership with Gram-sabha

Now in Gramdan the ownership of land is transferred to the village community. Some people are afraid that it resembles the Sino-soviet pattern where the individual does not own land and the desired increase in production does not materialise. Russia and China have also come to realise this truth. But there is a distinct difference between Gramdan and the Sino-Soviet model. There the ownership of land is appropriated by the state, while in Gramdan I want you to surrender it to your own village community or Gram-Sabha, which will be entrusted with all rights and privileges. Surely, there is a world of difference between the state and Gram-Sabha. While the state is something external, Gram-Sabha belongs to the village itself. The Government will realise land revenue from Gram-Sabha.

These days land ownership involves three rights—(1) of inheritance, (2) of cultivation, and (3) of sale or purchase. In Gramdan, while the first two are safe and secure, you have to forego the third one. You are at liberty to pass on your land to your descendants and to cultivate it as you like. But you can no more sell or mortgage it.

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Village Betrayal

However, if you are anxious to sell it; you can do so within the village itself with the approval of the Gram-Sabha. You will thus appreciate that land of the village will not be allowed to go outside the village. It will remain within the village. Selling village land outside the village is village-betrayal (*Gram Droh*).

What is the situation to day? In Vidarbha (the area comprising the eight districts of Nagpur, Wardha, Chanda, Bhandara, Amraoti, Akola, Yeotmal and Buldana of Maharashtra), fifty per cent of land belongs to those outside the village. This process goes on unabated. If this continues, land-owners will not be staying in the village and no village planning will be possible at all.

Stop This Selling of Land

You know very well that Mirjafar promised to pay Clive some money in lieu of aid received. But as Mirjafar had no money with him, he parted with some districts. In other words, he sold some districts to Clive. We call him a traitor and all that. You can easily see that if one who sells districts is a traitor, one who sells village land must be likewise held as a village-traitor. The owner sells land to those who live outside the village and do not work themselves. Production naturally goes down and planning of the village becomes out of question. The Panchayats today are not authorised to frame their own plans. But the Gram-Sabha of the Gramdani village is like the legislative assembly of the village. Its activities will not be confined to laying

roads, primary schools and markets, clearing the lanes etc., but will include increasing production, obtaining loans for the village and clearing of old debts etc. The Panchayats today have not this power of Gram-Swaraj. Their objective is noble indeed, but they are impotent. On the other hand, if you offer Gramdan and think of village interests as a whole, the Gramdani Panchayats will enjoy full rights.

Our villages to-day look to the Government for everything. The people are Government-minded, whereas the Government is not people-minded. The village is completely dependent. Our Village-Panchayats are not for stopping the exploitation of village. The rights coming from above must come from below itself. Why does not the land remain within the village today? Because people are anxious to keep in their hands both the land and the right of cultivation. But I want you to catch hold of cultivation alone, otherwise land will go to outsiders. That village land should remain within the village and not go out—such planning is not conceived of by any Gram-Panchayat. In fact, the village has no bottom to it. It enjoys some ordinary formal rights. I am anxious to see that land should not go out of the village without the consent of the Gram-Sabha. The Gram-Panchayat has no right to this effect.

Gramdan is such a unique programme that it has all the advantages and no disadvantages. Parting with one twentieth of land and thirtieth or fortieth of the annual income or produce every year will not be heavy. But it will preserve the land in the village itself and will do so

for generations. This will enable the people of the village to frame a complete plan for the village. You can have Sarvodaya Republics even as there are Soviet Republics. So doing, terrible problems like dearness, scarcity, unemployment etc., will at last disappear from the village.

Land-revenue in Kind

When the Government asked my opinion on the plan I had suggested that land revenues should be realised in kind and part of the salary be also paid in kind. You can execute this proposal in Gramdani villages. This will make your village an ideal village which will serve as a guide for Delhi too. But you cannot generate this power without Gramdan.

No Democracy Today

About seven thousand Gramdans have been offered in the country.* Surely the people residing there do not belong to any peculiar species. They are human as all of us are. I am, therefore, confident that if the District Parishad takes up this idea, it can turn into a basic plan of reconstruction. Today there is no public opinion. There is, in fact, a delegated democracy. We look towards the priest to carry out religious performances on our behalf and we pay him something for it. Indian women touch their husband's hand during religious ceremonies, believing that mere touch would suffice. Similarly, in the field of administration too, all

* Total number of Gramdans in India up to 15th Nov 1966 is 29, 444.

GRAMDAN FOR GRAM-SWARAJ

responsibility is thrown on the representative and we think that our task is done after casting the vote for him. Thus when everything is delegated, what remains in your hands? Save producing children, falling ill and dying, things which cannot be delegated to anybody. None will be willing to die on your behalf. I am, therefore, constrained to remark that there is no democracy today. It is obvious that in this situation, village problems cannot be tackled without Gramdan.

Need of Food Self-sufficiency

In 1951, I had warned the Government that it would be dangerous to rely on others for food-grains. Food self-sufficiency is essential even if there were a world federation. We have not been able to attain food self-sufficiency as yet. We are told that stress would be laid on agriculture in the next plan. But the situation today is that there is neither any grain in the village for the labourers nor for the Government employees. In other words, their life fluctuates up and down with the fluctuation of the price of grains. Both the central and state governments are favourably inclined towards Gramdan. They welcome Gramdan and promise all help. But who is to go to the people and explain it to them? It cannot be imposed by law.

Gramdan has been made easy. There is now no objection against it. It preserves the right of individual for cultivation. Individual freedom is there intact. Individual requires complete freedom which he must voluntarily surrender to society.

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What They Did in China ?

The programme of constructing buildings was once going afoot vigorously in China. Then they realised that food production had decreased. Immediately orders were issued that entire construction work be suspended and that all should take to agriculture. Some Americans went on a visit to China at that time. They flew across the country by aeroplane. They have written in their impressions that when they peeped below through their planes they were amazed to see that buildings lay abandoned in incomplete condition and that all construction programme was at a standstill. The Government gave one-eighth or one-tenth of the land to the individual land-owners, raised up production and saved the country. Besides, when it became inevitable to have food from without they continued their food production drive and also imported food. If a countrywide scheme of Gramdan were worked up in this manner, it will save India.

This Dependence Must Go

About eighty percent of our people live in villages and twenty percent in towns. But Government and planning are dominated by the urban people. Whosoever comes forward, sings in the same tune 'give me vote and I will do your welfare'. None has the courage to remark that your welfare lies in your hands. I ask them 'Pandit Nehru was a wise man, yet why was not success attained ? If electing a worthy man of his eminence did not serve the purpose, how shall electing you, the

worthless, be of any avail ?' They reply : 'Do it and try.' Well, how many times do you want me to engage ? Will there be anything in our hands, or the Government will do everything ? If everything like removal of untouchability raising marriageable age, etc. were to be carried out by the government, it will be regarded as a very dependent state. This dependence after Swaraj is very astonishing and lamentable. The only reason for this is that the educated have arrogated to themselves the right to plan. They say to the people : 'Ours is to plan and yours is to execute. We are heads, you are fools like blank boxes.'

Who Will Save Us from the Army

If people's own power does not take shape military rule is bound to follow. The country can be saved only through Gramdan. All agree about the efficacy of Gramdan. The essence of democracy lies in the control of people over the Government. Today the situation is just the reverse when the people are under the control of Delhi. What is required is that the people should plan and the Government should help in its execution. Today the Government frames the plan and then seeks the cooperation of the public.

People have become habituated to get all things carried out through their representatives. This tendency of entrusting everything to representatives is likely to render us indolent, careless, indiscreet and inactive. And if in this situation, military were to capture Delhi, what will happen ? Military regimes have come into power at so many places. We too are strengthening the army

in the name of China and Pakistan. We saved ourselves by spending crores of rupees, but who will save us from army ? There is no answer to it anywhere.

Build up People's Power

This has happened in Pakistan, Burma, Nepal, Egypt and recently in Algeria as well. It is known as 'Coup' in English language. In other words, democracy comes to an end within a day, within a moment. India's independence and democracy will survive only when our villages—the bastions of democracy—are strong and they control the centre. While items like post and telegraph may be run by the centre, all important functions should be performed by the people themselves without any consideration of caste, creed, language etc. We will then be able to establish here the socialism talked about by the socialists ; otherwise all the three viz., independence, democracy and socialism, will be in danger. If people's own power were not strong and Delhi were weak, the latter will turn into Billi (cat). We will, therefore, have to be very cautious in order to preserve power in the hands of the people in democracy. If the official power gains the upper hand, democracy will become vulnerable.

Had there been ordinary times a few Gramdans would have served the purpose, but not so now. There is urgent need for all villages to join Gramdan and bring about total revolution. See in Kerala where the sympathies of the left C.P.I. are with China. In case of a Sino-Indian conflict, they say that they will support China. In West Bengal, Kerala, and else-where too, though members of the left C.P.I. were thrown behind

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the bars yet they were elected to the legislatures. There is a rift in the Congress, aggravated by the departure of Pandit Nehru. There are divisions, among the socialists and communists too. It is, therefore, difficult to forecast the result of elections.

It is thus easy to see the dangers implied in people's helpless dependence on the Government and looking towards it for the meanest thing. There is no harm in the communists succeeding at the polls, but elections are not in their line. They have accepted it for your sake. After capturing the Government they will function in their own way—the way of the military—and reduce the people to serfdom. Like the communists, others are also stressing the importance of the army.

'Demos' versus 'Cracy'

You must clearly grasp that in democracy, what is important is not 'cracy' but 'demos'. Todary 'cracy' is strong, while 'demos', is weak. If after more than eighteen years of freedom, we are begging for food, arms and know-how from all over the world what have we got with us at our own home? Nothing but poverty and destitution. The country is, therefore, in a great danger. Were the people in India's villages to grow impotent, China will penetrate every village and China may also attack from without. They call it the way of liberation and designate their army as the army of liberation. They claim that their army, wherever it goes, liberates people instead of enslaving them. Poor, simple people accept it as truth too.

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If Marx Were Alive

I tell my Communist friends that I appreciate your feelings, of love, compassion, etc. But you do not realise the working of the world forces today. For every event you consult the book of Marx even as the Arya-Samajists look to the Vedas. You are Marx-devoted as they are Veda-devoted. But Marx was a wise man. He would have surely changed in this new age. But the communists are his followers. Once Khrushchev was the hero and they worshipped him like anything. But his expulsion has not brought about any visible changes in the Soviet policy. Yet all are dumb about his expulsion. Even the Indian communists have adopted silence on the subject. They say it is a personal affair.

Worshipping the Military

What I want to point out is that those who abide by democracy, must abide by the 'demos' though they maintain the military, even as those who may retain watchmen or guards at their home but keep them under their control and do not assign them the place of parents or masters. But some parties like the Jan Sangh, etc., regard the military above everything else. They do want democracy and would like it to function, but their ultimate reliance is on the military. The same is true about other political parties. Though they are democrats, yet if you scratch them a bit you will find that their God of worship is the military, even as a patient, tired of all treatments, recalls God. Had the military not established control over the people, I too would have

relied on it. But even in China, the rule of the communists is equivalent to that of the military.

Gramdan for Survival

Gramdan is not my work. I am a Fakir with no worries and no axe to grind. But you have your families and, therefore, this is your work. I can certainly see it clearly that if this work is not accomplished, the country will not survive. I would, therefore, ask you to study it and give your deep thought to it. The village should be the master of its destiny. I know that there is a hunger for *Samya-Yoga* (*communism*) in India as also the world over and we have to achieve this goal by means of compassion.

(Free rendering of a talk given at Paunar on 20th June, 1965.)

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II

Gramdan and National Defence

[*Vinoba*]

These days our country is passing through a very critical situation. There is a sort of war between our two sister countries—India and Pakistan. While Pakistan puts the blame on India, 'It is India which has attacked our country', India charges Pakistan of aggression. Thus blames and counter-blames are being apportioned at one another's door. Ordinary citizens cannot decide about the truth in these allegations.

War Harmful to the Poor

Though this is not the age of wars, yet the people wage battles as they have narrow and bigoted outlooks which they are not prone to give up. This may produce disastrous consequences. We must, therefore, ponder over our duty at this moment. Will we get nervous and confused? Will enrolment in the army serve the purpose? If you can afford to loose a certain number of people on the battle-field, China can afford much more. But it is certain that a war between these two nations will harm the interests of the poor in both. I do not know how the Chinese think about it. Nor am I aware of their resources and of the help they would be getting. But so far as India is concerned, she has contacts with the outside world and imports food and

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other necessities. In case of a war, it will be difficult for her to get food from abroad. We have to think over all these things.

Fate of Planning in War

I have repeatedly remarked that our five-year-plans are based on the assumption that there would be stable peace in the world. But what would happen if peace were disturbed and that too in our vicinity? Our imports and exports would suffer as also our industry and commerce. What will be the fate of our planning then? Its needs would not be met and our plans would fall! This planning of ours will be of no avail in disturbed situations. But the idea of Gramdan which holds ground in times of peace will continue to do so in absence of peace. In fact, when peace is disturbed Gramdan is the only way to meet the situation. When import-export trade is at a standstill, you do not get things from abroad, our plans are postponed, what will be the plight of our villages? How will they be saved? I am not talking of saving them from military attack but from economic onslaught.

Prices have soared up very high. It is said that price-rise is inevitable in economic progress through democratic process. But prices of articles of everyday use and of those which are required by the poor, are also mounting up. People are finding it difficult to purchase their daily necessities. This shakes the economic foundation of the nation. If prices of essential articles go beyond the reach of the common man, the economic structure will collapse. What will be the condition of

the village then ? It is, therefore, manifest that essential requisites will have to be produced and maintained in the village itself. In things like food for existence, cloth for covering shame, milk for children, medicine for the sick, etc., you cannot depend on others. The village must be self-sufficient in these basic items.

Defence of The Village by The Village

The country cannot be saved by the military or army. The defence of the village must be organised by the village itself. This does not mean that you must enrol people in every village and set up a defence force; my point is that the village is to be saved against the above-mentioned economic attack. The cities have little danger of economic invasion ; for things reach there from villages and money is also there to purchase them. The danger to the cities is of military aggression. Except for the villages in their vicinity, all other villages will be safe. But they do require immunity from economic aggression.

Gramdan as Defence Measure

I expressed this view before the leaders of the nation at Yelwal in September 1957. Almost all parties were represented there. I placed Gramdan before them as a 'defence measure'. They all discussed the subject and then unanimously passed a resolution encouraging and supporting Gramdan. The leaders did appreciate the role of Gramdan, but none of them cared to work for it. Had they given thought to follow their own observations, much would have been achieved by now.

Thus you have to prepare yourselves for the defence of the village. If you don't come forward who else will? You means whom? Those without education, without money, without land, and without any enthusiasm, cannot be expected to think about democracy and all these things—India is not so much democratically awake. Hence this responsibility falls on the important people of the village, i. e. on those who own land and wealth, on tradesmen, teachers, government officials, etc.

Need of Unity

For an effective defence of the village you must have sympathy towards all the people of the village. There should be unity amongst all. Its beginning can be made by donating one-twentieth of your land for the poor. I do not insist that everybody must give one-twentieth, some may give more and some less. But everybody must. Another way is that the leading people of the village should assemble and agree with common consent to part with one-twentieth or the requisite portion of the total land of the village for the landless. This step will unite the well-to-do of the village with the landless. It would be worthwhile if you donate cultivable land. If you give fallow land, get it ploughed by your bullocks. Also provide them with good seeds. Thus they will be able to grow rich harvest on cultivable land. There is no use deceiving anybody. Only noble acts will generate and enhance your strength. You can thus solve the problem of the landless in every village. There is no harm if you keep the remaining land with you for the moment.

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Role of Gram-Sabha

The next step is to set up a Gram-Sabha of all adults of the village. For an effective working of it, you should give it a portion of your produce. A donation of a thousand rupees or more is also required in the beginning to serve as capital. Industries can be set up in the village on that basis. A 'pattern' would thereby be evolved. Slowly all will change, but in the beginning the big people will have to sacrifice. If you do not make any sacrifice for the nation, will you be able to live quietly? You must see things while keeping your self-interest at some distance away. That will do.

Scope For Shanti-Sena

We will have to create an atmosphere for Gramdan and Shanti-Sena in India. Merely advising the Government will not serve the purpose. We will have to establish the efficacy of Shanti-Sena in internal defence as a substitute for the army in internal affairs. There are so many internal issues in India today. Also one finds much discontent. Again, there are party-differences and quarrels and conflicts too. We will have to show that these conflicts do not lead to breach of peace anywhere. For this, there is no other way except Shanti-Sena. So Shanti-Sena on the one hand and Gramdan on the other! By Gramdan we strike at the very roots of mutual conflicts and through Shanti-Sena we try to stop antagonism and disturbances and help the people solve their problems in a peaceful manner.

About three and a half thousand Gramdans* have been offered so far. All along I have stressed the need of strengthening Shanti-Sena. Then some people said, 'why do you jump to another programme before fulfilling the first ?' I am afraid they did not grasp my point. Even Gramdan is not safe without Shanti-Sena. In fact, Shanti-Sena is compulsory for Gramdan. If the police, the army and firing were necessary to maintain peace in the country, it would be meaningless for us to ask the Government to reduce its military force. People say it is sheer mirage to talk of disbanding the army in these conditions. Some allege that this programme of ours is impossible. My answer is that virtue lies in taking up only an impossible programme. In truth, I feel it is very essential. Could we do it even to a small extent we can ask the government to reduce the army.

Defect in Democracy

The peace or Defence of a country must not rest with a few people, howsoever good and virtuous they may be. In olden times, the king was supreme. Now-a-days there is democracy, and yet a minority at the top controls the entire show. Democracy is said to be a Government of the people, yet power has rested with only a few. If Bulganin or Ike went crazy, they could ignite the whole world. Thus the power to set the world afire or contribute to its well-being lies with a handful of people. Yet the whole does not get ablaze and peace

* Total number of gramdans in India upto 15th November 1966 is 29, 444.

is there—for which we should be thankful to God. This is a major defect in modern democracy which has to be amended and the power to render good or evil would have to be brought down to the common people.

Gramdan ensues freedom in every village and thus power is decentralized. On the basis of Shanti-Sena, every village will stand on its own feet. It will also plan for its defence and protection. Could we have a Shanti-Sena of this nature, the country would not depend on a few people. Then what is this Shanti-Sena of ours? It is meant for the transition period and in course of time it will be adopted by the people themselves. How can we pay them? Residents inhabiting vast regions will recognise them as soldiers and when peace is fully restored among the people, there will be little need of Shanti-Sena. Shanti-Sena will dissolve itself after dissolving the regular army, even as fire itself extinguishes after extinguishing camphor.

Strike the Malady at the Root

Why am I so impatient? The reason is that if we accomplish this task speedily we will be saved on all counts. If we do not hurry up, we will not be able to carry out our objective. From the point of view of national defence there should be enough grain in each village as to last for at least two years. This will be possible only when the village people will unite together and plan with unison. Our villages cannot be self-sufficient without a village plan of this nature and there can be no village planning without Gramdan. This is

why I value the importance of Gramdan from the strategic point of view.

Gramdan is the *sin qua non* for the liberty, progress and defence of the country. It is, therefore, essential that national planning should be based on Gramdan.

We must strike the malady at the root. Cutting the branches will not serve the purpose as they will grow again. The root is individual ownership of land. That has to be abolished and abolished voluntarily so that we may have a non-violent revolution which is always lasting and far-reaching.

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III

Gramdan : A Continuous Process of Revolution

[*Vinoba*]

It was in 1955 that I placed the idea of Gramdan before the people and four years earlier had come the Bhoodan. The former implied surrender of ownership of land and the latter its redistribution. I felt that the idea of Gramdan suited more the urge of society rather than that of self-interest. Thereupon I thought of a new plan to synthesize both. This resulted in the new conception of revised (*Sulabh*) Gramdan, which requires voluntary transfer of ownership to the village community and distribution of one-twentieth of land among the landless. The rest of land will remain with the owner and will not be given to anybody without his (or her) consent. All this is to identify the instinct of self-interest with that of surrender to society and cement them both.

This is a gentle process. In the beginning, I used to demand one sixth, but now I ask for one-twentieth. Formerly, while we (our workers) used to distribute land, now the donor himself does it and as a wedge we say that land under actual cultivation should be offered. The characteristic of the gentle process is that the onlooker must feel that you look to the interest of all and not of one party or group. We shall be able to enter the heart of one who is asked to make a sacrifice if he

feels that his sacrifice involves the welfare of one and all. Distribution by the donor is suggested—not only because it facilitates distribution but also because it binds the donor and the donee together with love. When we distributed land ourselves the credit went to the distributors and the generosity of the donor did not touch the donee. This was an evil process which had an element of violence in it. We did give one-third of land to the landless but it marked, in a way, our distrust in the donor. This is a process of violence. Now I intend to mend it.

A Mighty Transformation

Another difference between the old and the new pattern of Gramdan is that whereas in the former five crore acres of land under imagination was to be obtained in which the task of distribution was left undone, in the latter one and a half crore acres of actual land would be obtained which would be distributed simultaneously or almost so. Again, while in the former all kinds of land—good, bad and medium—were offered, only good land under cultivation would now be obtained. Besides, ownership of the entire land would be vested in the Gram-Sabha, meaning that instead of the names of individual residents of the village, there would be but one name of the village in revenue records. Thus is introduced a mighty transformation which paves the way for future progress.

Bringing Land-holder and Tiller together

In the new Gramdan, the landowner is expected to

distribute himself one-twentieth of his or her land under cultivation and join the Gramdan by surrendering the ownership of the rest of his or her land to the Gram-Sabha. His or her rights of inheritance over this nineteen-twentieth portion would remain intact. It will pass on to the descendants. Without his or her consent none can deprive him or her or the descendants of that land. I believe that the tendency to donate or share will be much stronger in the times to come than it is today. The sphere of consent would then be more natural and larger. People would gradually be ready to distribute land and carry on collective cultivation. For the moment people must be inclined towards Gramdan which is beneficial in every way. Distributing land to the tilling labourers will lead to mutual goodwill and affection. Surely it will not bring about any loss of production. In fact, it will increase. Both the landlord and the labourer will enjoy a sort of protection. Taking all these things into consideration I started the new pattern.

A friend asked me whether those who had donated land earlier would be required to offer further one-twentieth of their land to join Gramdan. I do not think so. Though it is good for one to offer new gifts every day, fresh donation is not necessary if land has been once offered in Bhoodan. What has to be done by old donors is to surrender ownership of their entire land to village body. Land will not be sold or mortgaged. Thus village land will remain in the village. I trust that this facilitation will encourage the instinct of Gramdan and strengthen the foundations of national defence.

Land-Ownership Should Go

Landholders living outside the village should also transfer all their land to the village community. Our goal is establishment of Gram Swaraj which is an impossibility if the village land continues to be owned by people residing outside it. Today India is free, but suppose that one portion of her is under France and the other under Germany, what will her freedom mean? if the entire land of India is not under her control, how can you frame a complete plan for the whole of India? Likewise, if the entire land of the village is not under its control, how can you frame a complete plan for the whole of India? How will you have Gram-Swaraj then? Individual land ownership has to be abolished so that village-land may not go out of the village. If individual ownership remains intact, anybody can sell or mortgage his land on such unnecessary items as offering dowry in daughters marriage.

Selling Land Like Burning Clothes !

There was a poor man who had very few clothes. The weather was awfully cold. He had little covering with him. He took off his clothes, set fire to them in order to enjoy the warmth. He felt happy and comfortable for a while. A few minutes later he found that his clothes were reduced to ashes but cold continued. This illustrates the working of the brain of a man who sells his land for daughter's marriage. It is very essential for Gram-Swaraj that right over the village land should not in any case go to outsiders. Gramdan is the mechanism to accomplish all this task.

I Have Come to Love You

When I went round the country for Bhoodan, I used to say to the people—‘I have come to loot you with love.’ One process of loot had already been carried on there (in Telangana). It was in that context that I used the language of loot. But now I say—‘I have come only to love you’. This enables me to enter everybody’s heart. There is no more the question of appearing before one party and displaying your love for it, be it a shower or invasion of love. But in Gramdan you have the splendid scene of loving both the parties.

Thus Gramdan implies not gift alone, but regular current of gift. In Bhoodan you became free after making a gift once. Not so in Gramdan where you have to give every year. Thus the entire populace—the children, the aged, the youth, men and women—will have a continuous training in the art of giving. Today you have *Bhog* (indulgence) in the world, nay *bhog-dhara* (current of indulgence). As an atonement for it, giving a gift once in a life-time is not sufficient ; giving must be ceaseless. That you have in Gramdan.

More Land Offered in A Village

Further, there is the likelihood of getting more land since we enter the heart of the people by love. Should the Gram-Sabha require more land, people would be offering the same undoubtedly. I can say it on the basis of my experience.

The story is of a village in Orissa. They offered me the Gramdan of that village. I inquired of them

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the details about land, landless persons, etc. It was found that donating one - twentieth of land did not provide adequate land to all the landless. Then they thought over the matter and willingly offered one-tenth. Once you find a place in people's heart, win their affection and confidence, and entrust them with the responsibility of setting up *Gram Swaraj*, they feel their responsibility and offer what is necessary and possible.

Onward Flows the Current

Let me clear one misgiving. Some people feel that the process of equalisation of land is crippled because only ownership is transferred to the village body. They argue that if ninety-five per cent of land remains with those who have always owned it and that if it cannot be transferred without their or their descendants' consent, it smothers the very idea of ownership-surrender. No, this is not true. For once the gift-stream begins to flow, the village takes the responsibility of caring for all and as our movement also forges ahead, the cause will continue to prosper. If we work for some time and then relapse into inertia, we would stifle both the programme and ourselves. On the other hand, if the movement continues and its flow goes on unabated, we will maintain our hold in the society. The world of to-morrow is bound to go onwards, not recede backwards. If we have any idea of *zeitgeist* we will realise that our children will go further than us, and do much more not less. This is the dynamics of the age. I, therefore, believe that the clauses embodied in the Gramdan are enough for the moment.

The Revolutionary Process

One more point before I close. You should be clear in your mind about the working of the revolutionary process. You should appreciate the difference between a programme which catches some people and then comes to a halt and a programme which envelopes millions of people and continues regularly. It is idle to pretend that the last word has been pronounced in the Science of Revolution. This science is revolutionary and yet in the making. Thinking in the background of non-violence, we realise that the process of a true revolution can only be non-violence-based. A process of revolution based on violence is verily a process of reaction which can only result in counter-revolution. I need not go here into its details. But you should know that the process which has the potentialities of wider expansion is bound to be more acceptable from the point of view of revolution. Likewise, in Gramdan I have not curtailed the process of revolution but extended it further on.

The fire of revolution is burning more brightly in the Sarvodaya brotherhood of ours than ever before. It is best illustrated by the fact that a leader of the eminence of Jayaprakash Narayan is attracted towards this programme. This shows that so far as the working of the revolutionary process is concerned, Gramdan goes further ahead than Bhoodan. Instead of cooling our fervour and the call for a revolution, it further rekindles it and strengthens the same.

IV

A Picture of Sarvodaya Social Order

[*Vinoba*]

Gramdan will usher in a new life in the village—when people will share their weal and woe, will care for mutual well-being, maintenance and defence, will villagise the ownership of land and will set up industries, schools, etc., in the village. In bygone days this responsibility was owned by the village itself. The village body provided work and food to the hungry. The same task would be accomplished by the Gram-Sabhas of Gramdan.

Today efforts are being made to organise Panchayats. Instead of solving village problems, these Panchayats are further aggravating them. They are creating feuds, dissensions and groupings in those villages which were formerly free from them. Villagers are fighting against each other. How long can the villages survive on the basis of this discord? The Gram-Sabha should realise its responsibility to rid the villages of this evil.

Constructive Work Without Gramdan is in Vain

The fulfilment of Bhoodan lies in Gramdan which paves the way for starting reconstruction work on Sarvodaya lines. We have been trying village reconstruction for three decades and more without Gramdan, but in vain. I do not know if anything was wanting in

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our efforts which were thorough and sincere. What was wanting was that the foundations of our work were not in land. I am talking of the pre-swaraj days. When the whole country belonged to others, where was the possibility of Bhoodan and Gramdan then? This thing was, therefore, impossible in those days. But we thoroughly realised that all undertakings without that were groundless. Therefore, ever since I hit upon the idea of Bhoodan, I have been pursuing it in preference to all other activities. Now it is felt that if Bhoodan is followed by Gramdan, a whole world opens up for reconstruction work. I can say on the basis of my experience that all constructive work, done today ignoring Bhoodan and Gramdan, is in danger.

Need of Loka-Shakti

I am pointing this out because I am anxious to provide a base to constructive work, which can be supplied either by official legislation or public approval. Should the State unify the land of the village and stop outside commodities from reaching the village, something can be achieved. But a step of this nature won't help creation of people's power though it will serve people's interest. If, however, the Government does not do it and we keep on indulging in reconstruction work without Bhoodan-Gramdan, neither people's power would be evolved, nor people's interest would be served. It does not mean that no service is rendered at all. Some is rendered but it is not what we call the Sarvodaya programme. You can carry out sarvodaya work by two

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methods—either on the basis of popular approval or on that of legislation for Sarvodaya work. But Sarvodaya revolution can be accomplished by only one method—Loka-Shakti or people's power. There is no question of legislative help in the same.

Government Can't Bring Revolution

The Government of today is based on the old pattern of Society. It tries to serve the people as much as it can without changing that pattern. It does profess to set up a socialist pattern of society. But socialism has so many connotations to the word that even capitalists can absorb it. Hitler's was also a socialist state. He gave it a high-wording name—'national socialist state'—with a double engine of nationalism and socialism. Yet it did not but lead to the disaster of the world and his own destruction too. Despite the will for it, the Government of today has no strength to alter the old structure. That is not its fault. Had I gone there perhaps. I too would have failed to do that. It is a different thing that a change of man introduces some changes. But it is quite possible that this work cannot be accomplished by the Government in the context of the situation of the country today. Mine is not to find fault with those who are running the administration. But I am stating the objective reality of the situation. The time has, therefore, come to work on the basis of people's power and people's approval. With a full-pledged support from the Government you can do some people's work but not bring about a people's revolution. We want to accomplish

both—people's work and people's revolution. That must have the basis of popular consent behind it—which is provided by Gramdan whereafter it becomes easy to plan for Gram-Raj.

Towards One-World Government

Every independent country of the world has its own Government today. There is, however, no world Government. But in times to come when the whole world would have one unified Government, these different countries would run their administration themselves, but the bigger world Government would think about their mutual relationships. It shall be incumbent on that bigger Government to advise the national Governments and also help them if possible. In case of a conflict between two nations, that Government's decision would be binding on both. As regards their internal problems all of them would be free. Likewise, there would be self-Government in every village whose inhabitants would live and behave as members of a single family. They will look after the needs of the village, while the government will offer advice or help if it could. All issues concerning the relations with other villages will go to the government. In this situation, the maximum power would vest with the villages. As a thread unites the flowers of different hues and smells and has no smells of its own save that imparted by those flowers, the government will serve the purpose of binding the villages with the thread of unity. While the villages are flowers, the government is the uniting link,

Two Years' Grain in Every Village

Eighty out of every hundred Indians live in villages. Suppose hundred people require hundred kilograms of grain, then ninety kilos should remain in the village and ten should be sent out for city-people, for the latter consume only half as much as their rural brethren. Even a city youth cannot take as much food as a village child, since the former cannot digest much. Those who do not labour hard or do strenuous work, have weak digestion. Hence ten percent grain would be enough for cities and the rest should remain in our villages. But the reality today is that village people preserve only as much food as may last three to four months and sell away the rest. If the rains fail and the crop is poor, they have to repurchase their sold grain at higher prices and if they have no money, they would go half hungry. If village people remain poorly fed, the harvest is bound to be poor. Hence there should be at least as much grain in a village as may serve it for two years. All this would be possible when the land belongs to the village and crafts of the village are developed in the village itself.

Let the Government Take Leave

People say that the government can do everything. Suppose a thick pipe is fitted at a place. Now which shall be more—the water of the pipe or that of the rains? The work done by the government would not reach every home and would be confined to a few particular spots where it would be conspicuously seen like the

water from a pipe. But the work done in every village is like rain water. May I offer a suggestion, viz., the government should take leave for a whole year as the schools do for two months. You may then see whether anything goes wrong. The farmers will plough their soil, the craftsmen will carry on their crafts, the shopkeepers will sell their goods and the buyers will buy, those engaged will be married, those due to die will die, those due to be born will be born and mothers will suckle their babies. How will they suffer if the government ceases to function ?

Mothers suckle babies in every home. Do they suckle for fear of imprisonment if they don't ? Thus you will see that people do most of their tasks themselves and yet you think that the government is like God. Some people deny the existence of God. If you ask them, 'Then who exists ?' they will reply, 'The government'. They are devotees of government, even as some are of devils and spirits. They remain under the illusion that all power rests in the government. But, actually, what power has the government got ? Did it ever sweep the floor of your house ? No, you do it every day and hence the house is clean. When your child falls ill do you send a wire to the Health Minister ? No, you yourself attend to your sick child.

Government a Bucket, People a Well

You are doing everything yourself and yet you believe that you cannot do without the government and that something can be done only if the government takes

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A PICTURE OF SARVODAYA SOCIAL ORDER

it up. Remember that functions of the village can be adequately performed by the village itself and that the government can discharge only such functions as concern the whole country. It is for the government to deal with railways, post and telegraph, mines, foreign affairs, etc., but the task of increasing the wealth of every village and solving the problem of the village should be tackled by the village people themselves. They should do everything with goodwill and affection. What is required is that the people of a village should take up the responsibility of that village themselves. Later the government should ask them how it could help them. They should offer their own conditions and then agree to some aid on that basis. You should primarily rely on your own strength and resources and accept some help from the government if required.

The government can be compared to a bucket while the people to a well. A very minor part of the people's strength lies with the government, even as an insignificant portion of the well water is contained in the bucket. But these days there is a great misunderstanding that it is the bucket which can hold more water. In fact, the strength of government resembles zero, while that of the people is like the figure of unity. Both combined together make huge strength even as one and zero yield ten.

The State Should Wither Away

If the people are kept aloof in democracy, the government has no existence of its own. You know that your elected servants form the government. Should

GRAMDAN

somebody say that his strength lies in his servants he will be taken as lame or invalid. The people must feel that we have appointed these servants to carry out our business at our behest and direction. These days you have the strange scene of servants framing the plan in the name of welfare state. While the masters should frame the plan, the servants should execute it. So the people of every village should intelligently prepare their own village plan and then demand complimentary aid from the government.

The greater the number of functions taken up by the people from the government, the more will non-violence flourish and the more smooth will be the process of the withering away of the state authority. This is why you find me engaged in a work like Bhoodan-Gramdan. The government is increasingly leaning towards our view-point. But there are some functions which the governments cannot perform. You can appropriate land by law and redistribute it, but you cannot thereby unite landholders' hearts, rather, law tears them asunder. The greatness of Krishna lay in his capacity for stealing hearts. The government can steal anything, but not the heart.

Slavery since Freedom

I do want to take the help of zero, but I want it to remain at its place. I don't want you to say that the government will do Bhoodan work. Tomorrow you can as well say that the work of protecting your child and providing medicine for it when sick would be carried out

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A PICTURE OF SARVODAYA SOCIAL ORDER

by the government. The people have become so inert and paralysed that they want law for everything, even for questions like the age for marriage, loving the Harijan brethren, etc. Thus the people feel helpless in every sphere and want the government to do everything. Since India's accession to freedom our people have become rather slaves. When Bihar was ravaged by an earthquake during the British regime, people from all parts of the country ran to provide relief to Bihar without waiting for the government. Again, when Gujarat was overtaken by floods, then too the people offered all kinds of help, which shamed the British Government into action. But what is the scene during these days of freedom? In 1954, there were unprecedented floods in Bihar. I was pained to find that though it was flooded all around Sitamarhi, yet its residents, instead of helping the flood-affected people, were making merry and the cinemas ran as usual. Had they not the heart to realise that they should avoid films for a few days and forward their savings to their distressed brethren? The truth is that they were under the impression that it was not for them but for the government to help the people. This is real slavery. You must not live under the illusion that whereas we were slaves during the British rule we are now free.

The rulers in olden days were so only in name. They could not regulate people's lives to any appreciable extent. People enjoyed complete freedom. Today the condition is quite different. An order issued from New Delhi reaches the whole country within an hour or so. The same is true

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about other nations. Thus those whom we elect can do more within a period of five years than what the Kings of old could do in fifty. The present rulers can serve the people ill or well as they choose. Thus the people have no initiative of their own.

Village as a State

Convert your village into a self-government. You must sit down together and unanimously decide about the exports and imports of the village. The village must develop the strength to return a purchaser from outside empty-handed. The village should mean a state. Should anybody ask you where you live, your reply should be—'I live in the village and that village is an integral part of the world. God is our ruler and we, of the village, run our village-state by mutual consent and co-operative effort.'

Today the planning for the village is done at Delhi or in the provincial capital. Your slavery will persist as long as you do not frame the village plan yourself. All the village adults, *i.e.*, men and women above 21, should form a village assembly which must unanimously appoint an executive body. The village assembly will run a village shop selling things decided upon by the village people. In case of marriage, the expenses would be shared by the village and thus it would eliminate the need of taking loans on this account. All disputes would be settled in the village itself by the village people themselves to which there would be no appeal. Today they appeal up to Delhi and formerly they went to the Privy Council at

A PICTURE OF SARVODAYA SOCIAL ORDER

London. In case of unsatisfying judgement they had to accept it as God's will. Now in Gram-Raj, the village judgement should be regarded as final. This will ensure real freedom to the village. Then the Delhi people will ask you to meet expenses for defence, transport, communications, etc., and like to levy some taxes. Your answer would be, 'It is we who run the village and our taxes are utilized in the village itself.' The Government will bend down, 'Alright, you keep fifteen annas and give us one anna out of your village revenue.' Thus you will be the real masters of the situation and get the reins of control in your hands. This alone will save the country. *Sarvodaya* is working towards this end.

Sarvodaya and Communism

They ask me whether Gramdan and all the rest of it is not communism. What do you mean by communism? While in communism, all land is owned by the state, in Gramdan it is owned by the village instead. There is no question of Government. There is combined ownership of the people themselves. In communism, the Government occupies all land and turns the people into labourers who are asked, just like bullocks, to work according to a plan. Though they say that the Government will ultimately whither away in communism, but it is a far too distant dream. Today the Government controls all power. Sarvodaya is just the reverse in which all power rests with the people.

Sarvodaya is a philosophy of life and every individual has an important place in it. When a family member

GRAMDAN

offers his total services to the family, does it decrease the importance of the member ? No, every individual, even a child, has his or her effective role in the family. Likewise, the importance of individual will be much increased, and not decreased, in Gramdan in which every idea emanating from any individual will be listened to and adopted after mutual deliberations.

Every Village to have its own Plan

This is the age of science in which small nations cannot survive much longer. Countries of the world have to come closer together. Today no village can stay in isolation. Hence the need for unity. Is it impossible ? No, this was a reality in olden times. In those days land was owned by all and it was not a marketable commodity. The same should be done now so that land may not be sold or mortgaged. There should be no landless in the village. Surplus hands should be diverted to craft and industry. It is not necessary to consolidate all land into one unit. Every village will have its own plan. The size of the farm is to be determined by experience. Sarvodaya is not worried at all about the size of farm or similar things.

Gram-swaraj

Some people hold that Gramdan means collectivisation. No, it does not. What I insist on is that every village should have its own plan, which can be modified in the light of the work done in the adjoining village. Thus much has to be done after Gramdan. It is futile to have Gramdan on the basis of Government help and

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A PICTURE OF SARVODAYA SOCIAL ORDER

assurances. The more we rely on government, the more we loose our independence. You can take up as much help as you require. But if you want to enjoy complete freedom, you must rely on your own strength and ask the Government to give you only that much aid as it can give to every village. You must not ask for anything extra or additional. We do not demand any special facility for a village because of Gramdan, but the Government must share as much responsibility of defending our village as it does of others. The rest will be looked after by the Gram-Sabha. You will thus appreciate that the idea of Gramdan is much different from communism and also from that of the welfare state. This is the picture of Gram-swaraj or Sarvodaya social order.

Freedom to commit Mistakes

After joining Gramdan you have to carry on your task yourself. You can approach the Sarva Seva Sangh or the community development people and others too for advice. You may consult anybody but you must act according to your own wisdom. Never mind if you commit a mistake. The one who attempts to rise will naturally fall. But one who does not ever attempt to rise, how will he fall? A mistake can be rectified. You can correct it in the light of experience. This is common in the home as well as in the village. This is what is called Swaraj. As Gandhiji said, 'Swaraj means freedom to commit mistakes'. The basic formula of Sarvodaya order is—'non-violent social order based on Gramdan and with village industries as its mainstay',

GRAMDAN

i.e., a social order in which the people of every village or locality should live like a family and manage their affairs with love by their own effort and on a unanimous basis. Sarvodaya envisages the social order as the family writ large. In a village structure of this nature, there will be least interference by government, which is duty-bound to give you some help as it receives taxes from all and is elected on behalf of the people.

Free Play to your Genius

You might wonder whether Gramdan will be reduced to government controlled co-operative or collective farming. No, there is no resemblance between the two. In co-operatives or collectives people are treated like bullocks, they are well-fed like bullocks, but are not consulted, again like bullocks—about the crop to be sown. Planning is done by the Government and people have but to obey. They will be provided with the requisite food, for the body, but not for the mind. On the contrary, I want the people to give full play to their mind and talent, to their genius.

This Euphemism !

At several places I have been pained to see a drama. There is a Government Farm of 500 acres where they avail of tractors as much as they can and employ labourers for the remaining drudgery. Finest seeds are sown in that farm. While the bullocks get the *danthal* to eat, the labourers working there cannot eat that grain. For them a 'cheap grain shop' is opened on the farm. This is sheer euphemism. For, 'cheap' really means bad or

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A PICTURE OF SARVODAYA SOCIAL ORDER

inferior; if they give the real name who would purchase it. Hence the euphemistic name. And giving them cheap grain is regarded as a major obligation. What a tragedy that our brethren are deprived of the very food they themselves labour hard to produce ! Nor is any plan chalked out for the development of their mind. The powers that be allege that those folk have no mind or brain. Theirs is only to work and not think. Very horrible indeed ! In Gramdan you will find nothing like this.

It is really a strange classification. In the mills too they talk in terms of 'hands' and 'heads'. In other words, those who work by hand have no brain and those with brain or head have no hands. Had providence improvised on these lines (that some should do brain work alone and some only hand-work), He would have provided some only with hands and others only with brain. Governmental plans do not bear any fruit as they are based just on this anomaly. They cannot contribute to harmonious growth and development.

Suffer and Learn

The main thing is that I do not want Gramdan for raising the production but for developing the mind. With the development of mind prosperity is bound to increase. Suppose the Government were to say : 'We are willing to take possession of your land and promise to pay you wages at the rate of rupees five a day', we would thankfully refuse the offer and reply, 'No, we can't accept your proposal. We can seek your guidance but

the decision to sow this or that seed will be entirely ours. Our progress will follow the growth of our mind. The Government might argue : 'So doing your scheme may fail and lead to a great loss'. To this we would retort : 'If there is loss in one village, there will be profit in another. In the light of the picture at one place in one particular year, we will introduce changes in the next and thus improve. It is better to work with our own brain and undergo some hardship than to work with another's and rejoice with borrowed joy.'

Intellectual and Moral Growth

People come and tell me that they could welcome Gramdan if it led to more food-production. Well, what is this idle talk of production? There is no shortage in U.S.A., which is the most advanced country in wealth, land and resources. But the largest number of suicides are committed there. There nobody feels satisfaction or contentment. The whole country is fear-ridden. Arms are mounting up. If something unfamiliar comes to pass anywhere they will cry, 'O danger ! danger !!' In case a communist leader is elected somewhere they will ask people to part with money for piling up arms. All live in perpetual fear. You may have any amount of dollars in your pocket but contentment is not on sale in the market.

Hence production is bound to go up in a Gramdani Village for it has gone down as much as it could. But even if it doesn't, I urge for Gramdan because it will provide an opportunity for the moral and intellectual growth of one and all.

V

Need For A Total Revolution

[*Vinoba*]

In the world there is not a single country where you find contentment. Whether they be affluent countries like America or USSR or the destitute ones like India or China, discontent stalks all over. Both rich and the poor suffer from discontentment. Nay, they are also dominated by fear. Thinkers of the world have, therefore, begun to feel that the whole humanity should have large heart which may encompass the entire mankind. We will have to rise up above the petty considerations of caste, creed, language, party, or province. People have become aware of the need of this change. But they hesitate to take the desired step in its fulfilment—to change their old frame of mind and way of life. This is the real problem before man today.

Mind Versus Heart

These days they are trying to reach the moon and some of the planets too, like Mars and Venus. Man's ambition is soaring very high and he is building such rockets as will go round and round for hundreds and thousands of miles. Possibilities of man's landing on the moon are getting brighter. He will also be contacting living creatures there, if any. Thus ideas are gaining

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momentum and the distance which appeared large and insurmountable are getting narrow due to Science. We all are witness to these high flights of Science but from the moral view-point, our standard of life is not rising up very high. I don't say that it is going down. But who can deny that the development of man's heart has not kept pace with the growth of his mind ?

Now the question is : What will inspire man towards developing his heart ? Well, his own mind is doing that. The mind says to the heart, 'I have taken so many strides ahead, but you are not coming up at all. There will, therefore, be no contentment in life ; society will also be discontent. Nay, violence will erupt in society for many reasons. Man has come to command such lethal weapons that if he were to use them out of anger or languor it will bring about an end of his very species. It is therefore, incumbent upon you to rise up and advance forward. This is the injunction of the mind to the heart. But the latter pulls the former downwards. The mind, now going further, adds 'All progress we make in Science is likely to be wasted if we don't raise up the heart.' That's why there is a clash of ideas all over the world.

Constructive Work Galore

I know many Sarvodaya workers who, full of goodwill, carry on one philanthropic activity or the other in their own spheres. This does spread some fragrance and improve the atmosphere. But it is not enough. These small acts of service are being performed throughout the world and but for them society would not survive. Often

NEED FOR A TOTAL REVOLUTION

people tell me that there is dearth of workers. I do not agree with them. Nor there is any reason for this complaint. Taking India's present population about fifty crores, I think that thirty to thirtyfive crores are employed in agriculture and allied pursuits. Thus they serve the people. Mothers also serve the babies. They are all workers, constructive workers indeed. You have the farmer, the carpenter, the weaver, the black-smith the shoe-maker, the teacher, etc.,—what are they if not workers and servants? The very existence of society signifies that crores of people are busy in *sewa* or service. Thus constructive work is in progress all through.

During the war with Pakistan, Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri gave us two words : *Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan*. Now why two? Simply because the slogan of *Jai Jawan* is not enough. In no case you can call upon the farmer to give up his farming. If he gives up his farming, what will you eat? How will society maintain itself without food? Hence the service which he is rendering must continue. But while carrying on his services, no farmer has the strength to bring about a change in the social pattern. Though doctors serve the patients it is not possible for them to produce such a society as may be free from disease. If we want to accomplish all this, it requires revolution in thought.

Complete Revolution

I have been touring round the country for the last fifteen years. It was a tour on foot for thirteen and a

half years and now because of old age I have taken to the motor car. I do not belong to any political party. Nor am I a member of any institution or organisation. I am just a human being. There is no label on my mind. They ask me why I undertake tours. I do not ask for vote, nor do I tell them whom to vote, and nor do I stop anybody from voting. Then why this tour? My answer is: The object of my tour is complete revolution. Nothing less will satisfy me.

Millions of people are engaged in good and useful activity the world over. The farmer, the carpenter, the railway signaller, etc., so many of them are doing a fine job. Mothers nurse the children which too is a very good work. Patients are served in the hospitals. Thus acts of service are performed through-out the world. Everybody wants love and service. If there were no love in the family it would turn into a graveyard. There is some joy in the world because of love in the family.

Compassion Should Rule

Who will deny the role or utility of *Karuna* (compassion)? The Red Cross unit accompanies the army and attends to the wounded and the sick. This is compassion. But this compassion can't stop the war. It has not the strength to wipe out war from the globe. On the other hand, this compassion creates zest for war and hides the evils of war from man's eyes. In the present society compassion is not the queen, but the maid-servant. It does not rule the society.

NEED FOR A TOTAL REVOLUTION

Total Revolution

The idea of Sarvodaya stands for complete revolution. I want to transform old values and norms and establish new ones. Hence the call for voluntary surrender of ownership and vesting it with the Gram-Sabha. Land-ownership is the basis of life. Some people stand for forcibly appropriating land-ownership from the individual and entrusting it to the state. In that case the State becomes the supreme arbiter controlling agriculture, trade and industry and everything else. This is State capitalism or Statism. Russia and China have tried it but it has not satisfied the people who become mechanical due to this system and lose all initiative.

What is my alternative for it ? I suggest that land should remain with the owner but its ownership should be vested in the Gram-Sabha. The landholder will continue to have rights of inheritance and cultivation. Besides, he will also donate one-twentieth for the landless. The point is that the land of the village should remain with the village and be not sold to outsiders.

Removing the Antagonism

What does it all mean ? While the Swatantra Party stands for the independence of the individual, the Communist Party pleads for the unfettered claims of the society. The two are poles apart; one urges the right of the individual, the other of the society. The socialist or communist will gladly sacrifice the individual for the sake of society, while the Swatantraite will not tolerate any kind of intrusion on the individual's freedom.

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GRAMDAN

Mine is an endeavour to absorb the substance of both. I want to preserve the freedom of the individual and replace appropriation by surrender to society. In other words, society must protect individual freedom and the individual, in his turn, must surrender a part of his produce, labour and wisdom in the interest of the society. Thus I seek to remove the antagonism between the individual and the society and make them work in a complementary manner. I ask one to defend freedom and the other to work with a spirit of surrender. I am anxious to introduce the same relationships in the family which should guarantee the freedom of all and for which all should make some sacrifice. Likewise the society must guard the independence of each of its members who, on their part, must sacrifice ownership for the sake of society.

This is Gramdan. I trust that you will appreciate its significance and offer every village of your block in Gramdan.

VI

Towards a Typhoon of Light

[*Vinoba*]

More than fifty years ago, on March 25, 1916, I gave up my home and resolved to take up public service. Thereafter I met Gandhiji in his Ashram at Kochrab and since then I have been carrying out his behest. Even after his demise I did not feel his absence and he has continued to inspire me as ever. Now after fifty years of this service—which has all been dedicated to God—I am entitled for rest and relaxation.

Entering a New Domain

But I am not going to relax. The instinct within does urge me to avoid gross variety of action as much as possible and to enter, what I should call, the finer domain of *Karma-Yoga*. If God summons me to him I have a right to go at this age. One does get a passport at seventy to depart. I am sure none will deny my right.

My conviction is that much work can be done through the finer mode of *Karma-Yoga*. (सूक्ष्म कर्म योग) I also believe that those, who after reducing their passions to zero, have merged themselves into God and His creation, help tremendously in the subtle way. After an age man has to cast off his attachment, illusion and greed, be it of social service or philanthropy. One and the traditional course is to 'go on carrying gross variety of

action and giving it up at the time when death comes at God's bidding. I am, however, inclined to take the second course—to enter before death the finer domain. This idea has been haunting me for two to three months.

A word about its content. For this finer *Karmā-yoga* the mind must be pure and action should run parallel to mental purity. As acting decreases, action gets stronger—one should be able to master a technique of this kind. How will it be possible? By purity of head and heart.

Meditation with Face towards the World

After a tour of hundred days in Bihar, I reached Jamshedpur where I fell ill. I saw an indication of God in it. I continued to think. I felt that time had now come to take to meditation with face towards the world—thinking of God in the form of the universe. *There is a way of meditation—keeping the eyes closed and mind turned away from the world. Here I am talking of not turning away but turning towards and my faith is that what could not be achieved by gross Karma-Yoga (स्थूल कर्म योग) should be necessarily achieved by the finer form. My illness confirmed my thinking.*

Also I studied my mental frame-work and tried to make the mind as pure and ego-free as possible. It depends upon God's will, not on Man's effort—yet it is impossible without effort. So I tried to purify as much as I could and continued my association with the movement. To me, this *Triple programme* is a worship of the Trinity. That I am giving up now. But as it lies in

TOWARDS A TYPHOON OF LIGHT

my mind, it will be a part of my meditation. I trust that greater consequences should now follow than those with *gross* (outward) action.

“Toofan”—A New Typhoon

At the Raipur Sarvodaya Sammelan (in December 1963) a resolution was passed for the Triple Programme embracing Gramdan, village-oriented Khadi and Shanti-Sena. I designated it as the worship of the Trinity. Thereafter I, as it were, fell ill at Paramdham (Paunar). In May 1965 was held a meeting of the Sarva Seva Sangh at Gopuri (Wardha). Until that time no active steps had been adopted to carry out the Raipur resolution. Thus a decision lay idle for about eighteen months. As Christ said, ‘If the salt has lost its savour, wherewith shall it be salted.’

Friends from different parts of the country, including Bihar, had come to attend the Gopuri meeting. Those of Bihar saw me at the Paramdham Ashram. I just asked them, “Well, are you ready for a ‘*Toofan*’ ? I can give you time.” They thought for a while and then nodded in assent. Thus a new word “*Toofan*” (Typhoon) became popular. Dukhayal, the Bhoodan poet, has sung :

‘There will be a Typhoon on earth,
The lamp of peace will be extinguished
Darkness spreading wide :
Give up the right of ownership.’

In my mind I modified it thus :

‘The lamp of peace will burn bright,
Light spreading wide.’

GRAMDAN

I said to myself that this would be a new type of typhoon which would lead to light and life all round. A typhoon can be constructive, luminous and bright even as atomic power can be constructive, productive and peaceful.

You can easily see that Bihar which was at the lowest rung of the Gramdan ladder a year ago has now come up. Instead of some 250 Gramdans in May 1965, the present figure exceeds eight thousand. What a long distance you have covered. Now you must see what you have to do. Well, the whole of Bihar has to join Gramdan. You have to work and aspire for nothing less, more if possible. Bihar can release such force as can influence China too. That light can spread to Afghanistan, Iran, etc. But *Bihar-dan* is the minimum you have to accomplish.

Both Quantity and Quality

You have so far brought small villages and the hamlets in Gramdan. Many people complain to me at this development. I ask them to have patience. It is from small gramdan that I hit upon the idea of Block-dan. As more and more small gramdans followed, some friends of the Sarva Seva Sangh asked me, "What is this? In your temptation for quantity, quality is falling down. Let us do a little work, but it must be good work. Why this rush for numbers?" I replied, "I will not give up this temptation. I will forsake neither quantity nor quality. It is wrong to imagine that quality and quantity cannot go together. Those who believe that the two contradict each other understand neither sociology nor

psychology. There is no conflict between quantity and quality. The truth is that the increase in quantity enriches the quality and the enrichment of quality raises the quantity."

A block, Pratappur by name, in the Hazaribagh district, has joined Gramdan. Thus a beginning has been made in Bihar. Once you arrive at a unit you have to add zeros to it and every zero makes it ten times as large. Now that one block-dan has materialised in Bihar, more are bound to follow. Should you ask me that if one out of six hundred blocks is obtained in a year, how long will it take for all of them? To such calculators I generally put the counter-question—"If it takes fifteen days for mangoes in my village to get ripe, how long will it take for those in five lakhs of villages?" If Pratappur can join block-dan why not Chandil block and others? There are no such special species of people in the former as are different from those in the latter. That is why I say that Pratappur has paved the way for other block-dans. We have only to work and forge ahead.

Collapse of Industries

Recently I recieved the report of the Gramdan work done in the Madhubani sub-division of the Darbhanga district. According to the 1961 Census, there were about 1900 persons per square mile (640 acres) in that region. It would be nearly two thousand now. Making allowance for houses, roads, rivers, bridges, etc., it comes to 2000 people on every 500 acres, or about a quarter acre for every person. Unhappily we don't have many

crafts and industries there. In fact, the process of killing village industries, started before Swaraj, has continued. I am afraid that the number of village industries crushed since Swaraj exceeds the number of those set up since then. During these eighteen years more industries have collapsed and fewer ones have grown.

Poverty and Communism

Under these conditions a blooby revolution is a natural consequence. The idea of Communism will easily spread in areas like Darbhanga where land is so scarce and industries rarer still. The same is the situation in many districts of Bengal where population has also gone up and many people have migrated from East Pakistan. Communism is bound to make headway in Bengal as also in Kerala. Communism flourishes in those places which are thickly populated, where poverty bounds, the poor have no hope and the land is owned by the upper classes who squeeze on mercilessly. This creates bitter disappointment which fathers Communism. I may easily lay down the three simple requisites for Communism : want of craft or industry, less land per capita and the few at the top usurping all land and resources. You find it in Kerala, Bengal, parts of Bihar and other provinces.

Need for Hard Work

But to me this is a very hopeful situation. As there is field for Communism in Madhubani (Darbhanga) there is for Sarvodaya too, provided we work hard. We must make the landlords understand that their well-being lies

TOWARDS A TYPHOON OF LIGHT

in parting some land for the landless and entrusting the ownership to the Gram-Sabha. I think that they will easily grasp this reality and willingly join Gramdan in large numbers.

This idea of Gramdan has received the blessings of even orthodox Communists. They have gone to the extent of saying that it offers an alternative to Communism. But they are doubtful whether Gramdan will catch the imagination of the people. They tell me—'If it catches, we confess, it will absorb the finer elements of Communism and will be better than it. But people will deceive you and won't accept Gramdan.'

Go Ahead

I, therefore, want you, the workers of Bihar, to rush to the places fulfilling the three conditions above. All the poverty-stricken and highly populated areas must join Gramdan. I am sure they will, provided you work as intensively and strenuously until December 1966 as you have done in the month of May. You will meet tremendous response. Also you will be able to clear off all doubts and misgivings about Gramdan which will be acclaimed as a very practical proposition. The higher the summit you decide to negotiate, the taller will be your achievement. •

VII

Gram-swaraj Delayed is Gram-swaraj Denied

[*Vinoba*]

Mahatma Gandhi taught us that there should be Gram-Swaraj in villages in free India and they should be self-sufficient in primary needs like food and clothing. For various reasons the country could not act up to his teachings and the national planning took a different turn. However, thanks to the concern shown for India by Pakistan and China, we have now begun to realise the significance of Gandhiji's advice. Eighteen years are not a long period to acquire wisdom for right action. Personally I can wait for another eighteen years. But will the world situation permit us ?

Sitting on the Edge of a Volcano

We are sitting on the edge of a volcano ; unrest prevails all over the world. None can be sure that things will remain peaceful for even a year or two. At the moment there is hot peace between India and Pakistan and China may launch an offensive any time. In that case fighting will not be confined to the border and any village or town can be a target. I submit that Gramdan is not only an effective defence measure but also a major defence itself. Defence on the border is like raising your hand to protect the head when hit, but the real defence-

GRAM-SWARAJ DELAYED IS GRAM-SWARAJ DENIED

has to be offered in the villages which can be converted into strong fortresses on the basis of Gramdan. We would have to make villages self-sufficient in food and think afresh how far things like tobacco cultivation and milling of rice can be allowed to go on. The entire policy needs reorientation for making the villages stand on their own. This task can be accomplished by the village people themselves if they are entrusted with full responsibility.

Come Together for Gramdan

It is wrong to regard the villagers as incapable because they are illiterate. They have experience of thousands of years behind them. For they directly read the book of nature whose study is denied to the educated because of their theoretical obsession. In fact, their complex mind cannot easily grasp simple things like Gramdan which the common man can easily catch. Its very simplicity makes it difficult for the fraternity of the learned and the political parties. But I trust that the reality of the situation will lead them to sink their petty differences and come together for Gramdan to rebuild the country.

Due to our serfdom for several centuries our people developed an inertia and indifference to the course of events with a philosophy to suit our slavery. Little wonder we do not react to the situation instead of taking it as ordained by fate. But after the attainment of freedom, this inertia must go and people ought to be stirred by some common inspiration. Unhappily, self-interest loomed large and fortune building has gained

ground at the cost of the masses. I submit that Gramdan is a positive programme which provides a collective inspiration to stir us all to action and participate in the noble venture of nation-building.

The Secret of Gramdan

The secret of Gramdan lies in uniting hearts and raising everybody's prestige. In the villages we have the labourer, the landlord the trader and the banker. The relations between them are marked by distrust and each tries to hoodwink or exploit the other. Gramdan seeks to change this state of affairs and bring them together in the Gram-Sabha to which the labourer contributes a part of his labour, the landlord of his land and the banker of his money. A little sacrifice on the part of each cleanses the heart and infuses mutual confidence among them.

Land should cease to be a marketable commodity. Selling land means losing land. Once you invest the ownership with the Gram-Sabha it becomes secure and can be utilised in the interest of the village. I would, therefore, ask you to have a common ownership of land, prepare your own cloth, consume your milk and butter, stop growing jute and tobacco, give up drinking and live together as in a family with amity and love. I claim that Gramdan will not harm or hurt anybody but will benefit one and all. It will save Bihar and the nation.

Unprecedented Crisis

Our country faces an unprecedented crisis today. There is appalling poverty in the country and dissatisfaction

tion prevails among the youth. The education they get disables them from physical labour and the greater the number of educated the greater the unemployment. It is a pity that the old system of education continues in free India. On August 15, 1947, I declared at a public meeting in Wardha town that as an independent country should have a new flag it must have a new system of education as given to us by Mahatma Gandhi with any changes, if necessary. But even today we stick to the stereotyped system started by the British rulers for their own purpose. In the matter of food also we were equally careless. More than fifteen years ago I urged upon the Planning Commission the need to make the country self-reliant in food but to no purpose. Likewise, as regards defence I suggested Gramdan as a defence measure in 1957.

Let us honestly confess that in the three fields, so important and vital, as education, food and defence we have been utterly negligent and short-sighted. However we must make amends now to recover lost ground and forge ahead. I submit that if we want our democracy to flourish and also to lift up our famished brethren we will have to introduce checks and controls in the society one after another.

Who will protect us from the army ?

As in fascism or totalitarianism our ultimate reliance in democracy is on the army. It is there to defend us against external invasion. But, if in course of time the military gain the upper hand, who will then protect us from them ? I hold that the army must be under the

control of civil administration and the civil administration under that of the people and the people under that of moral values.

During Pandit Nehru's days his name was a power and was more effective even than his own personality. Pandit Nehru and a pair of bullocks could do the trick everywhere. Now that Pandit Nehru has gone, how long will the bullocks save you? It is therefore very essential that civil administration must prevail over the army and the people must have their say which they do not have in the present indirect democracy where in candidates are selected by the parties at Delhi and imposed upon the people who have no option but to vote for them irrespective of their individual merits or demerits. It is a denial of the inherent right of the freedom of the people. Needless to point out that if the present state of affairs is allowed to continue our entire structure may collapse any moment.

I believe that Gramdan provides the right remedy for it. By enunciation of moral values in the society it introduces a process of checks as will keep the whole society under moral control, I trust our people will realise the gravity of the situation and wake up to their responsibilities. India's democratic character is on trial.

Three Vital Factors

After a lapse of eighteen years it has now been realized that the country must be self-reliant in food. The Union Home Minister has declared 1971 as deadline for it. God only knows what will transpire in India,

GRAM-SWARAJ DELAYED IS GRAM-SWARAJ DENIED

Asia or the world during these six years. Meanwhile the population of the country will also increase by six crores.

To feed the whole nation we must take into account three vital factors, viz. the material, the human and the planning. The material factor implies the supply of good seed, manure, irrigation facilities and the like. More important is the human factor which operates the material one. Today our labourers want to work as little as possible and the land-holders want to pay them as low as possible. Like the two bullocks to a cart one tries to shift the burden on the other. Little wonder that the cart moves with a painfully slow speed. A reconciliation of attitude between the labourer, the landlord and the village banker is the *sin qua non* for growth of more food. The third is the planning aspect which requires a reconsideration of economic policy like encouraging money-crops, say tobacco and jute, at the cost of food and also polishing rice etc. All these three factors must be earnestly attended to for food self-sufficiency.

Hunger and Communism

Besides, I submit Gramdan is a positive defence measure as well. You have set up an army on the border to meet the Chinese aggression. But if there is dissatisfaction among the people who are denied even their basic necessities and disparities continue to widen among the people the Chinese doctrine will infiltrate into every village. It is well known that people sympathetic to Chinese Communism are there in Kerala, Bengal

and some other parts of the country. Wherever there is hunger there is communism. Gramdan offers a peaceful way of meeting this challenge. If you do not adopt it and if China were to attack near Sikkim or Bhutan and Pakistan also makes a push from its eastern wing, and if we just loose a small battle one day though we may win the war alright, who can then stop bloody revolt in villages ?

Delay will be Fatal

With all emphasis at my command I must declare that India is very insecure today from within and that there is no other way for us except Gram-swaraj through Gramdan. I am therefore anxious that Gram-swaraj must be established speedily, since Gram-swaraj delayed is Gram-swaraj denied even as justice delayed is justice denied. There is no time to lose now and you must accomplish this mission in the shortest possible time. Lord Buddha has said that good things done with a slow speed aggravate evil.

My dear countrymen, at this old age of seventy and with no family or estate to look after, there is nothing in this world for which I care a bit. But the terrible and insecure situation of the country allows me no peace or rest. I have not come to frighten you but to give you a warning lest you may be caught unawares. It is easier to fight the Chinese and Pakistani invasion at the border than the one within. You have to give up your slumber and plunge into action with all your soul and with all your heart. Any further delay is bound to prove fatal.

VIII

A New Experiment in Human History

[*Jayaprakash Narayan*]

In the modern age, Gandhiji gave us a new idea in the context of the current problems facing the country and the world. And on the basis of that idea the country launched a mighty struggle or movement for freedom. Gandhiji taught us that though we should not nurse any kind of envy against the British we should root out the very foundations of the British regime as it was an evil in itself and symbolised injustice. But there should neither be any hatred in our heart for the British nor should we do any harm to them. Perhaps it was for the first time that man was imparted this unique lesson of truth and non-violence in the political context. The people of this country achieved success to the extent to which they turned this lesson into practice. The country was partitioned because we did not follow Gandhiji's teaching in its entirety, could not live up to it and could not act according to it.

After Gandhiji's departure, his idea of truth and non-violence remained before the people and continues to be so even today. It is there before them who went into politics, before them who did not go into politics, and before the common people. But the same is not true, about his ideology and programme of Sarvodaya, the responsibility of whose implementation, by its very

nature, cannot be shouldered by the state. If this ideology finds favour in society and the society adopts it in practice, then the Government can follow in its footsteps, can strengthen or support it and can make its own contribution towards it. But Sarvodaya is not such a viewpoint as may be implemented by the state, administration or law. It is simply not possible.

Not Power, But Service

This is why Gandhiji who had before him the good of the establishment of such a society in free India as was free of exploitation and coercion and was marked by the good of all, by equality, fraternity, and minimum Government, resolved not to accept power himself. He kept himself absolutely aloof from it. He even went to the extent of suggesting the formation of a Loka Sevak Sangh to attain this objective and told the Congress people that since the Congress had achieved one great goal and had still to attain greater goals—of economic, social and moral freedom in terms of India's seven hundred thousand villages, the Congress should withdraw from the arena of party and power politics and enter the field of service to the masses. He had stressed the view that India was to be built by the dint of people's own initiative, their own strength and their own might and organisation. He looked forward to the setting up of a non-violent social order in the wake of the attainment of economic, social and moral liberty and visualised the Government and administration running under the control of the forces of non-violence.

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A NEW EXPERIMENT IN HUMAN HISTORY

We could not follow Gandhiji's Path

Unfortunately, Gandhiji went away from our midst too soon after freedom. He did not get an opportunity to lead the nation along that path and we were deprived of his leadership. Fortunately, however, his ideas and views are there before us. But events started taking shape on different lines after Gandhiji's passing away. Those who came into politics could not carry out the task of building a non-violent society. And to whatever extent they could—to the extent to which it was the responsibility of the state—they did not pay heed to do that much. The Loka Sevak Sangh of Gandhiji's conception could not come into being. Nor could the Sarvodaya movement gather such strength and vitality as would make the state follow it. Events so conspired that the state held the lead and everything else followed in rear. In other words, every aspect of social life became dependent on the Government and looked towards it. This was one reason, there might be other reasons ideological reasons too. For, it was not clear what similarities were there in Sarvodaya and socialism, what differences, etc. Due to these manifold causes, the Sarvodaya ideology could not lay its hold upon the society. Again, the late Pt. Jawaharlal Nehru avoided it saying : 'Sarvodaya is a very high path for which we are not fit and that we are fit only for socialism for which we should exert ourselves.'

When I say that the country did not go along Gandhiji's path even to the extent to which it could, I do not mean to criticize anybody. For, never had the

Government declared or any resolution been passed by the Parliament or any plan been chalked out by the Planning Commission to the effect that they did not want such a society as could be called the Sarvodaya society. Thank God that they never condemned this ideal. At times, those in authority or office expressed their faith in this ideology though they never turned it into practise.

A New Way through Bhoodan

While Vinobaji was on his tour in Telangana, he struck upon—even as salt-Satyagraha occurred to Gandhiji—Bhoodan Yajna. In the beginning, people expressed their apprehension that nobody could offer land on request. For, great is the attachment for land and all know that the question of five villages led to the Mahabharat and that even today blood-feuds and murders are committed because of tiny bits of land. Yet, thousands and lakhs of acres of land were offered and Bhoodan came to stay. Thus was opened a new way before the country showing how a great social task of the magnitude of distributing land to the landless could be accomplished by the path of service, the path of touching the heart of the people, the path of arousing the inner human chord, the path of awakening the spirit of religion and ethics which is slowly fading away, both in individual and social spheres, the path of love and compassion. An example of it all held itself aloft before the nation.

Sharing and Fellow-Feeling

But this Bhoodan-Gramdan movement of Vinobaji is not one merely of distributing land among the landless. This is an attempt to raise man higher up. This is an endeavour to make you realise that you must share your wealth and possession with those who are denied the same. Land belongs to God. All wealth is His. We all are His children and even as children have equal share in their father's property, we all have in that of His. This movement seeks to explain this idea of sharing and fellow-feeling. Vinobaji put this idea before the people and they came forward with their donations with love. This land-distribution could also be brought about by the methods of bloodshed and of law. But that does not change anybody's heart. You cannot force a man by sword or law to recognise his responsibility towards his landless and resourceless neighbour.

Land has been a bone of contention from times immemorial and if you try to see what religion and ethics have done or could do to solve this problem, you will find that Bhoodan has given an adequate answer to it. It is regrettable that even in a God-intoxicated land like India, people were not attracted towards this movement to the desired degree. All this leads one to the conclusion that our religion and ethics are only at the surface and do not go deeper. Our spirit of religion, our reliance on God, our faith in our rishis and saints and seers, all of it is only at the fringe and does not penetrate into our interior.

Evolve according to Our Genius

Now this is the age of science. Western civilization is invading us fast. New fashions are emerging. Our youngmen require drain-pipe trousers and bush-shirts etc. But we should see to it that we are not carried away in this cyclone of western fashion. If we are blown away in this storm of western modes, western culture, western life-values, what shall it lead to? I don't think that in a hot country like India, terelene trousers can ever be more comfortable than the *dhoti*. You may inflict all sorts of inconveniences and miseries upon you in the name of fashion, lest you may not be considered 'modern'. We adopt such fashions as have been rejected by the west. It is really a tragedy that something condemned in the West becomes the craze of the fashion-enthusiasts here. If we imitate, we can never be 'modern'. It is a different thing if we try to become 'modern' from within. We should accept good things, good ideas, good points of culture, science, etc. from without. We cannot live like frogs in a well. But we must know ourselves and recognise what we are. If we forget ourselves we will be nowhere. There will neither be India, nor Indian-ness. Nor will there be any Hindu, Jain or Buddhist. I will also like to tell my Muslim and Christian brethren—little matter that their religions came from outside—that theirs are also Indian religions. They also bear the stamp of Indian culture. Their soul is Indian. Thus we have to evolve according to our own genius and avoid deceitful imitation which would wipe us out.

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IX

Gramdan and Democracy

[*Jayaprakash Narayan*]

It is regrettable that our people have not tried to grasp the importance of democracy. They have unfortunately developed so much faith in the power of the State that though they lament the wrongs done here and there and blame the authorities or ministers for acts of omission and commission yet they believe that state alone can set right all these ills and problems. The state has been trying the same for the last eighteen years. Be it the question of Kashmir or Pakistan, of poverty or corruption, exploitation or socio-economic disparities—they are all before you and you know how state has failed to solve them all these so many years.

Some hold the view that if the Congress cannot deliver the goods, we must entrust the responsibility to others. Well, you may do so by all means. But there is little possibility of it in the context of the present situation. The reason is that there are many parties in opposition to the Congress. During the last elections Congress secured no more than 45 per cent votes, less than half, but these 55 were divided amongst the opposition parties which failed to displace the Congress. So I don't think that any material change is possible in this regard. But even if it were true and a party other than

the Congress were to capture power, you cannot be sure what improvements will it usher in. In Kerala, they have seen not only Congress rule but also Communist rule PSP rule and also the President's rule. Yet the people there are very much disappointed and 'frustrated' and have developed a sort of cynical indifference towards state and political parties.

Dictatorship—No Solution

Many among the middle-class people often flaunt the view that the parliamentary pattern of democracy does not suit us and they show their preference for dictatorship. I am afraid that they are talking of dictatorship only so long as dictatorship does not come into power and they have not had a taste of it ! It is painful to find the educated intelligentsia talking in terms of totalitarianism. Perhaps thinking themselves as animals they also want to turn others into animals, or perhaps they are under the illusion that they themselves would become dictators or enjoy a dictator's close confidence and reap all benefits themselves.

However backward our country may be and whatever be its shortcomings, we must all take pride in the glorious fact that the people of India deliberately and with open eyes decided that they would establish Democracy here.

Democracy disappearing fast all over Asia

We are men and not animals. We will neither enthrone any king or tyrant at Delhi nor crush ourselves un-

GRAMDAN AND DEMOCRACY

der the heels of any dictator. As men, we will always be free and live as respectable citizens of a free society. And we will work to set up such a social order as will ensure freedom to every citizen and guarantee economic, social and religious liberty to one and all. We have resolved to establish a democracy of this nature and we have been pursuing that path for the last eighteen years. India's is the biggest democracy in the world today. This is no small thing ; in fact, it is very great thing indeed. It is, therefore, very pitiable to see people calling themselves low or degraded and decrying democracy.

Look at Asia from Japan in the east to Israel in the West. What do you find save totalitarian regimes everywhere ? Except in India, you do not see democracy anywhere. India is, as it were, the sole bastion of democracy in Asia and Africa. We have a new republic in Japan and it is difficult to say about its future. As regards democracy in Malaysia, Ceylon or Burma, you know how much democratic they really are.

Leaders of the eminence of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru are rare indeed. Yet any member of the opposition could say in the Parliament the hardest and cruellest thing about him, about his family, about his party, about his Government, about everything. Is it possible in U. A. R., China or Indonesia ? Nor is there any country in Africa where democracy can be said to be functioning in the right spirit. Even the biggest leaders there, some of whom are my personal friends, *e. g.*, President Nyerere of Tanzania, and about whom one could never dream that they would take to the dictatorial path and who

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regarded themselves as democratic socialists—all of them are now openly saying that democracy can function only on the basis of single-party system, and none in these countries can set up a party in opposition to the ruling one and raise his or her voice against it.

You find the same scene in South America or in Europe. Take France, known as the mother of revolution, where General De Gaulle rules the land. How much power he has concentrated into his own hands ! It is the same *Tamasha* all over the world and India stands alone in glaring contrast. This is a country of about five hundred millions who have gone to the polls thrice. The Parliament is functioning alright as also the state legislatures. The newspapers publish what they choose. The opposition parties say and do what they like. All this is very glorious indeed ! Our democracy is a symbol of the height of our culture, of the depth of our ideology and of our free spirit.

Basis of Democracy

But what is the basis of this democracy ? People's own strength is always regarded as the sheet-anchor of democracy. The main characteristic of democratic society is that the people generate their own strength to bring about the desired changes and solve many of their problems with it. Some form of this people's strength has manifested itself in Gramdani villages. No democracy can function successfully as long as people's initiative and leadership do not take shape in every zone—village, block, district, province and the nation.

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GRAMDAN AND DEMOCRACY

It is needless to state that a society devoid of people's own strength can never flourish or survive. This is borne out by the experience in the field of sociology, state-craft and economics. Due to her continued slavery, India lost this fundamental strength of hers. In ancient times the glory which India attained was due not to her kings and princes—who were always fighting amongst themselves and in her thousands of years of history India hardly knew peace for a century or two at a stretch—but due to her people's resolve and initiative. True that there were some exceptional rulers like Ashoka and Samudragupta who contributed to her rise and prosperity to some extent, but the real credit should go to her people who organised the pattern of life in villages and cities, and set up the whole social and industrial structure. India's ships carried cargoes to every part of the world and she produced her own wholesome influence on nations and civilizations. But all this strength of the people came to an end during the regime of the British rulers who also made special attempts to kill it. While the power of the kings had decayed of its own accord, that of the people was systematically destroyed leading to our capitulation and enslavement.

Gandhiji entered the scene and he infused new life in the people. He had conceived of the formation of Loka Sevak Sangh to recover people's strength, which, however, could not materialise. We did continue to pay lip-service to it, but we could not generate it. In very exceptional circumstances some such situation might have developed in some villages as would have induce d

the people there to do something. But the general experience is that whatever has been done anywhere is due to aid received from the state or the block, and even then nothing of fundamental import has been done anywhere. Under the inspiration of the Government, the political parties and of others too, many programmes have been launched but they have all failed to enthuse the village people and build up their strength. For instance, compost pits were dug, but it is an open secret that most of them were refilled. The people are not able to learn the simple thing of obtaining manure from cow-dung.

I do not believe that our backwardness is due to our democracy. It goes without saying that if we, the people of India, were better than what we are, if the Indian administration were finer than what it is, we would have made progress with a tremendous speed. Nevertheless, some thing has been achieved—they are working in fields, factories and shops, schools and colleges are opening up, etc. It is true that thousands of such schools have also sprung up as have no teachers, no books and no equipment. When quantity arises, quality is bound to decline.

These days they talk of corruption. It is there but not to the extent to which it is imagined. But what is its remedy? Some people hold that the advent of a dictator would finish it off in no time. Anybody who likes may turn a dictator. Dictators are not made.

I will Fight Dictatorship to the Last Drop of my Blood
But I want to tell you that so long as I am alive, I will

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fight dictatorship and will resist it to the last drop of my blood. For, I do not see such an utter degradation of human society in any system as in dictatorship. I am a man and want to live as a man. I do not want to sell or mortgage my mind and my soul to anybody else. If somebody were to tell me that I will have to read only whatever the Government prints, I will have to speak only whatever the Government dictates, I am not prepared to accept it on any account. Nor do I believe that dictatorship can bring about an end of corruption.

Role of Gramdan

But I think that Gramdan is making a vital difference. It is developing the strength of the people. I am sure that the moral power generated in the wake of Gramdan and its organisation will help quick development of the village. The stress of our entire movement is to impress upon the people the need of solving their problems by their own efforts. Their good or welfare lies in their own hands, not in those of leaders or political parties. If they organise themselves to meet their problems, outside aid will automatically follow. They must have the capacity to utilise that aid. Looking towards or making a search for a leader is not going to provide a key to solve any issue. Had, however, there been no democracy and one individual or one party had unlimited power to command, things would have been entirely different.

Pandit Nehru once said that if a train ran late in Mussolini's regime, the responsibility was his for he was

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the dictator of Italy, while the responsibility in democracy lies on every citizen. It is incumbent on every citizen to run the democracy properly. The people should be wide-awake and conscious. It is idle to depend on a saviour or liberator who will solve all the problems. True that in critical situations, democracies too require giants of the calibre of Roosevelt and Churchill, etc., but in normal times, persons of the stature of Attlee, Macmillan, Hume and Wilson suffice who are a bit higher up than the common people. In fact, if a specially gifted leader comes to power in democracy, the latter faces a great risk since that leader is wont to disobey the discipline of democracy. What is, therefore, required is to make the democracy strong through the development of *Loka-Shakti* as envisaged in Gramdan.

X

Panchayati Raj and Village Development

[*Jayaprakash Narayan*]

There are two main programmes run by the state for national reconstruction — Panchayati Raj and Community Development. The rest are covered by these two. But the outcome of these programmes is just the opposite of the aims, and objects with which they were launched. I am closely associated with the Panchayati Raj organisation. I know how these Panchayats developed in the country. This work was started with high hopes and expectations. While framing the constitution, they just forgot to include Panchayats in it, though Gandhiji was alive at that time. Later a new clause, No. 40, was added to the constitution to provide for the establishment of Panchayats. But Gandhiji visualised that decentralisation should be the hall-mark of administration—in other words, maximum power should rest at the lower levels and the minimum possible at the top. Jawaharlalji began this Panchayat programme with great enthusiasm. I am sure that if he had not taken an interest in it, the Congress would have never touched it even with a pair of tongs. I see how Panchayati Raj is taking shape in the country, specially in my home-state of Bihar. The Panchayati Raj legislation has been enacted. The Panchayati Raj

was set up in two districts. It will follow in two more districts. But what of that ? How long will it take to cover the whole country with this speed ?

Decentralisation for Democracy

Once in Delhi I told the Prime Minister that Panchayati Raj was in great jeopardy all over the country. Quick came the reply, "The problem before me today is whether centralisation is necessary for an efficient running of the country or decentralisation." Poor souls, sitting at the centre they look at everything in that light. But it needs little reflection to state that in democratic set-up, it is decentralisation (and not centralisation,) which can lead to an efficient and smooth course. There is no other way. But if it is centralisation, it shall be nothing short of dictatorship, little matter who the Prime Minister is.

In fact, centralisation and democracy contradict each other. How can one man or a cabinet manage the whole country ? There can be no real progress worth the name unless the people guide their affairs themselves, organise in villages and towns and wards, join shoulders together to solve their problems of their own accord, and thus gather their own strength. How long can a dictator go on whipping and prodding you up ? Today, Panchayati Raj faces a great peril and so also does the Community Development programme.

Obstacles to Development

You know the type of society we have in our villages. It is the same pattern all over the country. There are

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PANCHAYATI RAJ AND VILLAGE DEVELOPMENT

the higher caste people and those of the lower ones. Again, there are the resourceful and the landholding classes as against the resourceless and landless ones. Thus there are distinctions of caste and class, which we have done little to eradicate. Due to Zamindari Abolition some land reform was implemented. Ceiling laws were also enacted in some states. Despite all this legislation, however, no outstanding changes could be introduced anywhere. The village remained as it was. And in that village money was dumped in from one side in the name of Community Development, and power from the other in the name of Panchyati Raj. What was the result ?

Vinobaji's Warning

Vinobaji had given a warning long ago that this dumping would lead to unhappy consequences. Pandit Nehru has gone on record making the painful observation that all the money, so enthusiastically spent in the community development programme, failed in its purpose of uplifting the down-trodden and the lowliest. It resulted in bettering the lot of the happier and resources-owning sections and could not benefit the people at the bottom. Reports and documents of all sorts have been prepared and they have been shelved. The truth is that nothing can succeed in the village unless you bring about an economic revolution.

Power with Middle class

Now this revolution is not easy to attain, since all power rests with you and I, the middle class people. We

GRAMDAN

are in Government, in administration, in offices, in business, everywhere. Though ours is a small group yet it commands every power. Millions and billions of rupees spent in the name of national reconstruction have come to us, the pockets of the middle class folk, be they in cities or towns or villages.

If power somehow came somewhere in the hands of one of the lower class, these of the upper ones wove such a conspiracy as to render him ineffective. In case there is some moral strength, there are some intelligent people you have the backing of some social workers, and the B.D.O. etc. are also good people, there something is done. Nothing elsewhere. How to change this state of affairs ?

Gramdan for Panchayati Raj

Suppose you have to set up a steel plant at Bhilai or Rourkela, it can be easily done by the centre by the help of aid from Russia or Germany or elsewhere. But if you have to do something all over the country and in every village—you want to bring about community development, you want to improve agriculture, you want to industrialise the village, you want to encourage education, you want to build clean villages, etc.—the official programme for it all is gradually getting slack and lifeless. There is a feeling that it should all be wound up. So far as I am concerned, I see only one way out. If you really want a Panchayati Raj and a true programme of community development, you can do so only if you introduce therein the heaven of Gramdan.

PANCHAYATI RAJ AND VILLAGE DEVELOPMENT

In case you do not bring about any change in the mental outlook of the village, in its social set-up, in its economic frame-work, in its mutual relationships, you cannot alter the shape of the village as it is today—with its reactionary forces, its caste and class distinctions and its entrenched differences. You may throw any amount of money into it or put Panchayati Raj or Community Development in its lap, or any number of schemes for any industry or project—you will find that all this leads neither to the village reconstruction nor to the betterment of the poor and the impoverished. With the old order and village system intact your pouring in money in the name of community development and power in that of Panchayati Raj will amount to adding insult to the injury. You will do more harm than good. Then what is the way out ?

The Key Lies with Gramdan

I submit that Gramdan offers the desired key to change the whole mind of the village. When you join Gramdan—you voluntarily surrender the ownership of your land in the name of the village society, part with some land for the landless poor, sit down together with all adults in the village assembly and contribute regularly a portion of your field-produce or wages or earnings to the village-fund—you do bring about a real transformation in outlook, in attitudes, in mutual relationships and in the day to day affairs of the village. It leads to the creation of a responsible and responsive society. The changes that can be brought about even in the

GRAMDAN

initial stages by Gramdan are of such a vital character as cannot be obtained by any amount of official work, or programme of political parties, or activities of Panchayati Raj or community development, or five year plan programme, or 'rural programme' or 'man-power utility programme', etc. All these programmes will never be able to match, in quality or quantity, the attainments of Gramdan.

XI

The Triple Programme

[*Jayaprakash Narayan*]

As Gandhiji, while launching Salt-Satyagraha or earlier, gave us the triple programme of boycotting educational institutions, law courts and legislatures, Vinobaji also gave us a triple programme sometime ago. Though small to look at, vast potential strength was hidden in Salt - Satyagrah and other programmes of Gandhiji. The same is true about Vinobaji's programme, which seeks to arouse people's self-reliant power, strengthen our democratic foundations and eliminate the evils of poverty, unemployment and corruption.

The three items incorporated in this Triple Programme are *Gramdan*, *Shanti-Sena* and *Khadi*. None of these is a new programme. But they have been given a new turn and the three taken together have built up a new image. As Vinobaji says, they are not separate items but indivisible parts of a *Trimurti* (Trinity). You might have seen the *Trimurti* at the Elephanta caves (near Bombay) which is claimed as a master-piece in sculpture and the art and power embodied therein are regarded as unique in the world. Likewise, this Triple Programme is an embodiment of rare strength and new spirit.

This programme is mainly meant for the rural areas.

But it does not mean that it has no concern with cities or that it cannot be implemented in cities. Take the programme of Shanti-Sena, for instance. Organising Shanti-Sena is more important for cities than for villages and its programme has great value in the urban areas. Likewise, if the idea of Gramdan catches the imagination of the country it will influence the life in cities too. The same is true about Khadi. But the real centre of all these programmes is the village and if they succeed therein, they are bound to produce an impact on cities and towns. Hence the need of working them at the rural end.

The Hidden Iceberg

These days in our country the State is running many projects and running them on a gigantic scale. Vast is the expanse of the state machinery which seems to be much bigger than the people's own strength, particularly so because the latter has not yet found adequate expression. Leaving aside this state-managed activity, we will find that of all programmes being carried out on a popular level or by the different institutions or organisations in the country, Sarvodaya movement is the biggest, very wide-spread and most important too. About forty to fifty thousand workers are engaged in this mission. If a scientific assessment were to be made of this movement, the result would be miraculous indeed. But who is to do it? Those in authority do not care for it. Some influence of this movement is obvious, while much of it is latent. I have often compared it to an iceberg—part of which is

THE TRIPLE PROGRAMME

visible above the surface and a greater part is submerged within water. Likewise, the deep influence which the Sarvodaya movement has exercised on the mind of the people is undisclosed. Whatever has been actually done or performed as a consequence thereof is there before you. It is no mean achievement indeed.

India today faces manifold problems—one more complex and dreadful than another. They may be related to the internal situation, *viz.*, increasing dearness, unemployment, corruption, poverty, inner tension or discord, etc. or to the international situation, *viz.*, our conflicts with Pakistan and China, etc. People outside nurse the hope that India would solve them in her peculiar way and place an example of her own. This triple programme of the Sarvodaya movement claims to offer a solution of these various ills.

When I place before you the triple programme, you might wonder what Gramdan, Shanti-Sena and Khadi have got to do with rising prices, falling value of the rupee, growing unemployment, injustice, corruption, etc.? You might well call us mad or irresponsible people who are harping on their own tune when the country is faced with such serious issues. I won't blame you for holding this view. I shall make an attempt to show how this triple programme is connected with all these diverse problems.

Not Possible to Fight on Many Fronts

At the back of all perils and problems facing our country today, the main thing is that we have to fight

simultaneously on many fronts. But it is simply not possible to wage war on all those fronts. Much of our failure is due to our vain attempt to do all things at one and the same time. On the other hand, if we properly organise all our strength—strength of 300 million people, 300 million minds and 600 million hands—it will amount to colossal strength indeed. But all that strength is lying dormant. We have to awaken it up and give it a living shape.

The other day, a resident of a village, Pakribarama (in the Gaya district) gave me an application for getting a drain of the village cleaned. He started with the assumption that it was for the village people to spoil the drain and for government or any other agency to clean it. With this mental attitude, whither will the country go? Had there been a dictatorship, the dictator would have forcibly, given a broom in his hand and caned him to clean that drain himself. But this is democracy in which you should realise your responsibility. I have written to him to take up that work by the help of the village people themselves. It is really very sad that we have not been able to grasp the importance of democracy. While the country is plunged in physical and mental languor, we are aspiring to fight China, Pakistan and poverty, all at the same time.

Degradation in Dictatorship

There is a feeling with some people that dictatorship will solve India's problems. This is a grave misconception. Do you know what dictatorship means? Today

THE TRIPLE PROGRAMME

you can speak here whatever you like against the Government. You have not been turned into dumb-driven cattle. But where-ever there is dictatorship—be it of the fascist and Nazi type or of the communist variety or of the ordinary military pattern—there the common people—nay, even the intelligentsia and the biggest intellectuals too—are reduced to the status of animals when they cannot think with their own mind. The dictator bids you to think what he wants you to think, to speak what he wants you to speak, to do what he wants you to do. Where-ever there is dictatorship there is no humanity. It is an animal world, not a human one. I, therefore, regard it as a great glory of India that she did not take to dictatorship and opted for the path of democracy.

But there is some advantage in being an animal. You know that a farmer will necessarily feed his bullock though he may go hungry himself—for he has to plough the field with it and fatten it in order to demand a high price for it. He will, therefore, try to maintain the bullock to the best of his resources. But a bullock is after all bullock. If, however, you choose to be a bullock a dictator might improve your lot as compared to the present one. But if you think that dictatorship can solve any problems, I am sure you are grievously mistaken. Perhaps you are not in your senses.

Technological Revolution

Despite dictatorship in China, there are scarcity and famine and so also were they in Stalin's Russia. Nor do

I believe that Russia and Germany would have made less rapid progress had they followed the path of democracy. In fact, the progress would have been far greater still. What has been achieved in those countries is not a feat of dictatorship but of science and of the technological revolution brought about during the last two decades. If we weigh the scientific advance made in the last two centuries against the technological development of the last twenty years or so, the latter will outweigh the former. The striking progress that meets the eye is a fruit of the eruption of the industrial revolution. All empires have vanished during this period and India too has cast off her chains. Though we have made substantial advance during these eighteen years, yet we could not reach the standard of the countries of the West, because of our low level of technological development and of want of higher education in science and other subjects.

Corruption in Dictatorship

No doubt there is corruption in India. But dictatorship is not its panacea. After Marshal Ayub came into power in Pakistan, a terror overtook the country. Many people were arrested and punished, which reduced a good deal of corruption. Slowly, however, the disease began to creep in again. Instead of accepting a bribe of rupees five for carrying out a certain piece of obligation, they demanded rupees fifty. The higher the risk, the higher the charge. Recently, the story of misappropriation of millions of Roubles came to light in Russia. It was not misuse or ~~wastage~~ or damage, but pure and straight

THE TRIPLE PROGRAMME

embezzlement. Can there be a dictator more ruthless than Stalin or Khrushchev? Yet corruption is rampant there. When new people come they devise new underhand means.

Here you generally talk of corruption in terms of money. But what about the untruthfulness in vogue in dictatorships? There is no end to the falsehood perpetrated there among the people, to the moral turpitude to which they are subjected, to the immoral dealings which they mutually carry on, etc. Now what is this if not corruption?

During the latter half of the fourth decade of this century most of us were Communists and had intimate contact with the Communists in different countries. We felt amazed how Stalin got rid of one leader of revolution after another by execution. When we raised a voice against this horror we were dubbed as agents of American imperialism. Now when Khrushchev came into power he revealed all that had been committed during Stalin's days. May I know whether there can be a greater corruption or moral degradation? Accepting illegal gratification is just a common lapse. But imagine how false charges were framed against those who were the right hand men of Lenin and who had accomplished the biggest ever revolution in history, and how they were executed after being condemned as fascists and traitors! I cannot conceive of a greater corruption or more disgusting conduct.

One Remedy—Gramdan

I do not deny that corruption is rampant in our country on a vast scale. But what is its remedy? I see

No other solution save that the people should be conscious, be wide-awake, be organised and that the people's own strength, *Jan-Shakti* should be at once alive and conspicuous. In Gramdan you have an organisation of the people, a certain harmony among them, a distinct consciousness which encourages a feeling of collective living and community spirit. There is no question of offering any bribe there and getting some money for jobs like well-digging, etc.

I believe that as people join Gramdan and gather some strength, corruption will come to an end. I do not say that no corruption ever took place in a Gramdani village or the Government officials, overseers, etc., did not accept illegal amounts in Gramdani villages. But if you compare them with other villages, there is a world of difference. Gramdan instils a certain fear among the officials. This is why there is some hitch over Gramdan from their side. While the higher officers are in favour of Gramdan, those at the lower rungs of the ladder—who are addicted to illegal gratifications or who want the people to remain stupid, defenceless and voiceless so that they may continue to exploit them in their own self-interest—are opposed to Gramdan. They see it clearly that if the public goes out of their hands, they will cease to reap undue benefits.

Officials and Ministers are Servants of the People

There are some who ask me to enter politics, accept power and then reform the Government from within. I do not presume to have some such power as to succeed

THE TRIPLE PROGRAMME

in bringing about the needed change. In fact, no single-individual can do it. The question then poses itself—how to bring about the desired reform? You may as well think over it and you will reach the conclusion that the remedy lies in the awakening of the people, in their organisation, in their strength. Whether it be the field of trade or administration or education, the people come in direct touch in every case and if they are well-organised, alive and alert, corruption will end in no time.

Several cases have come to light in which a B.D.O. or some irrigation or agricultural authority, having done something unfair in the block and attracted the notice of our Sarvodaya workers (who organised the people against that wrong or injustice), was frightened by that organisation or force of public opinion and the Government had to take action against that employee or transfer him.

In democracy, the people are masters and all these officials or employees are their servants. Be he a record-keeper, B.D.O., District Magistrate or Chief Secretary—they all are servants. The Prime Minister and other ministers who are representatives of the people are servants too. Now if a servant were to demand an illegal sum from the master, what else can it mean save that the master is not conscious of his role and inner strength? True that one man cannot fight this evil, but it can be easily dispensed with if the people organise and become stronger as anticipated in Gramdan. •

XII

Towards Non-Violent Socialism

[*Jayaprakash Narayan*]

The four main pillars of Gramdan are :

(i) The village sets up its *Gram-Sabha* (village assembly) of which every adult, male or female, is a member ;

(ii) All the landholders of the village transfer the ownership of their entire land to the village community or *Gram-Sabha* ;

(iii) All the landholders donate one-twentieth of their land to the *Gram-Sabha* for the sake of the landless of the village ; and

(iv) They set up a *Gram-Kosh* (village fund) in which the landholders regularly offer one-fortieth of their produce and the salaried people or wage-earners contribute one day's earning (or one-thirtieth of their income) year after year.

Now think over the influence of these four on the village. They usher in such changes as have not been brought about either by legislation or by panchayat or by community development or by any other agency, scheme or programme. Gramdan creates a new environment and converts the heart of the people to an appreciable extent.

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TOWARDS NON-VIOLENT SOCIALISM

Land-Ownership No More

The most important impact is that Gramdan strikes a blow at the sense of ownership which is spreading fast the world over. The people are persuaded to cast off land-ownership and surrender it to society. Through an educative process is generated the feeling that land should be shared in common and that its ownership belongs to God or people, '*Sabai Bhoomi Gopal ki*'—a realisation which cannot be achieved by law or gun or any other means. This is a very vital moral and spiritual effect of Gramdan.

Many people abide by individual ownership and regard it as their prerogative. The Swatantra Party is particularly anxious for the preservation of this right. But who will oppose or condemn a man who voluntarily abdicates ownership of land? Land problem unlike in America or Africa, is the most baffling in India where land per capita is hardly an acre. Much of the conflict or bloodshed in our villages has land problem at its root.

When Vinobaji was in Kerala, some of the leaders of the Roman Catholic Church met him and said that individual ownership was a 'sacred' right. Vinobaji observed, "I do not deny it. Nor do I strike at it by force, legal or physical, of any kind. But if somebody abjures that right of his own accord and willingly transfers the ownership to society, what shall be the verdict of your Roman Catholic Church over it?" They thought for a while and remarked, "It is very welcome."

In fact, the very beginning of renunciation of ownership is a great achievement. These days they talk of

socialism, democratic socialism, nationalisation, etc., but what will be its shape and how will you bring it about? Today there are some fifty land-owning houses in a village and fifty landless ones. Is it socialism? If you ask the votaries of the various types of socialism as to how they propose to recast society on socialist lines, they have no clear answer.

A fundamental postulate of socialism is that all such wealth as leads to production of further wealth should belong either to society or should be under its control. The truth is that no wealth can be produced without the co-operation of society. From this point of view we should regard society as the owner of all wealth. At any rate, socialism insists on the direct social ownership of wealth-producing wealth. Now if they were to proceed by law to vest land-ownership with the village, how will they get votes in the next elections? This task cannot be accomplished by law. But if a large number of villages join Gramdan and the people generally accept this idea, a legislation may be enacted to that effect. Thus voluntary surrender of ownership produces its own healthy reactions, both internal and external. Its consequences—political, economic, moral and spiritual—are clearly visible in the village.

Village as a family

The second important thing is the village fund. Suppose a village joins Gramdan and sets up its village fund—in the form of cash or grain or both. Now according to the rules of Gramdan, the first priority in

the expenditure of this fund will be given to the disabled people, orphaned children, helpless widows, and the unattended sick of the village. In the village as it is today, none cares for anybody, howsoever miserable or distressing be his plight, and the latter has to linger on and meet his end in sheer decrepitude and desperation. But this shall cease to be after the village joins Gramdan and the people realise their responsibility to their most afflicted brethren. Therein are laid the foundations of a responsible society.

Ours is a democracy. We vote a Government into power. We are the masters of the Government. It is, therefore, quite irresponsible on our part to think that the Prime Minister or the Chief Minister would devise ways and means of solving our problems. The State will carry out its functions, but we should not forget that we too have a duty towards our neighbours and village people. The village fund helps us in establishing that cordial relationship. The village is transformed into a family and comradeship and fellow-feeling mark the life of the village.

Gram Sabha : The Old and the New

You have heard of *Gram-Sabha* in Panchayati Raj. It does not enjoy very many powers. Nor does it own the confidence of the people. Suppose there are 150 to 200 people in a *Gram-Sabha*. But when you call its meeting, hardly 20 persons turn up. The meeting is thereby postponed because of want of quorum. The meeting is convened again and according to the rules there is no

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question of quorum this time. Then the few who attend the reconvened meeting pass resolutions and budget, etc., as they choose. So goes on the *Gram-Sabha* in which the common people have no interest. It is a problem before the country how to render these *Gram-Sabhas* active and alive.

On the other hand, take the *Gram-Sabha* of a Gramdani village. In the Government revenue records, there are no individual names and all land is in the name of the new *Gram-Sabha*. Thus all payments due to the Government, *viz.*, revenue, taxes, etc., are done by the *Gram-Sabha*. Thus the village develops a personality of its own. There is the village fund at the disposal of the *Gram-Sabha* which also distributes the land donated by the landholders for the landless. Now this *Gram-Sabha* enjoys a certain status and when it will ponder over village questions, *i.e.*, food production, industries, sanitation, planning, education, etc., it is bound to meet a favourable response. It will approach village problems with the outlook of a family and arrive at unanimous decisions in the interests of one and all.

Answer to Communism

Another attraction of Gramdan is that it enables us to fulfill the call and urge of the social transformation as desired by the modern age. Though we attained independence eighteen years ago, yet no distinctive social change or revolution has been achieved. Despite the abolition of *Zamindari* and dissolution of princely states, no major change is visible. And this must be an object

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of serious concern to us, specially when we face the Chinese or the Communist challenge. If the Indian society is not so recast as to answer this challenge, I am afraid it will not be possible for us to halt the invasion of Chinese Communism. You might stop the Chinese Army at the borders but you cannot prevent the Chinese ideology unless you bring about a basic change in society.

I believe that Gramdan offers a solution to this problem. This is a programme which enunciates effective change in agrarian society—moral change leading to evolution of *Jan-Shakti* (people's self-reliant power). The very fact that Gramdan introduces community ownership, bidding good-bye to individual possession of land, is a great thing in these times.

Political Parties not for Revolution

There are many political parties in our country. They claim to be revolutionary and much more. I usually go through their programmes, policies, statements, etc. I find that they have nothing revolutionary to offer or carry out about agriculture or land. They do talk about land reform but not about land-revolution. The Congress, PSP, SSP and all other parties which call themselves revolutionary, do not go beyond what is known in socialistic language as bourgeois reform.

Let me tell you that imposing a ceiling on land-holdings is no revolution. Had ceiling been the criterion of revolution, General MacArthur would be hailed as the greatest revolutionary known to the world. For, when

he took over as the Military Governor of vanquished Japan, he carried out two main programmes—setting up a democratic pattern of Government and redistributing land. He fixed a maximum ceiling of three acres.

Now I ask you whether in Bihar where the pressure on land is so heavy there is any political party which can announce a three-acre ceiling. None ! At the most they will plead for exemption from land-revenue for uneconomic holdings or for realisation of revenue in the form of income-tax, etc. Obviously, there is nothing revolutionary about it. These are items of petty reform. But if possession changes hands and individual ownership is transformed into community ownership, it is revolution indeed. No political party has the courage to call for abolition of land-ownership, because the public opinion is not in favour. But if one or two hundred thousand villages in this country join Gramdan, any party can abolish land-ownership by legislation. None will then oppose it. However, if any political party issues a statement today to the effect that it would change private ownership into community ownership, even a person holding only half an acre of land would not vote for that party. For, community ownership is regarded as synonymous with State control and State management. And State ownership of land implies that the one who begs for votes today becomes the owner tomorrow on being elected as a representative. They will, therefore, not vote for him. On the other hand, if it is clearly explained to the people that ownership of *Gram-Sabha*, as compared to that of the individual, will be conducive to their own well-being

TOWARDS NON-VIOLENT SOCIALISM

as also to that of the village, they will be willing to forsake ownership, not by force of law but of their own accord. This is a great feature of Gramdan.

Non-Violent Socialism

In the early days of the movement, ownership of the entire land of the village offered in Gramdan was vested with the village community which also utilised it on community basis. I would call it pure and unadulterated socialism or communism. Surely, it amounts to a mighty revolution if land is owned by the village, is redistributed by the village among its residents on the basis of the number of members in a household (with some minor adjustments in exceptional cases), and is cultivated on a community basis in the best interests of the village. You cannot think of a revolution greater than this.

I do not regard collective agriculture imposed by law in Communism as revolutionary, because it is all done by force or coercion. But in Gramdan, land was actually owned and maintained by the village and when people met from time to time, they chalked out plans for future action. Suppose cholera breaks out and a family loses several members or some people migrate from the village the *Gram-Sabha* will then sit down and redistribute the village land. The land was not only owned but also cultivated by the village community. It was a big revolution.

But it meant such a tremendous change as could not be brought about easily everywhere. It could serve as an example at some places. Vinobaji and others felt

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that no social revolution could be accomplished if thing remained a rare illustration and was not commonly adopted. He then modified the Gramdan. But its basic feature of replacing individual ownership by community ownership was maintained intact. Stress, however, was not laid on immediate occupation of land by the community and it remained with the former owner. Adding a few other clauses to it, Vinobaji gave Gramdan current form which is now popular all over the country.

Towards a Gramdani Bihar

But if this idea of madiffie Gramdan does not spread fast, it will not lead to a social revolution. It may, however, certainly lead to the same if Bihar offers ten thousand Gramdans within six months. Surely, you won't sit idle after that. You will go on working to increase that number and you will feel enthusiastic enough to say that we will have Gramdani Bihar by 1969. I can see the whole picture of the coming non-violent revolution. But I wonder what the votaries of violence would do in its place.

No political party in India professes to follow violence. After a country-wide arrests of CPI (Left) members, when the Union Home Minister remarked that they (communists) proposed to support violent activities he was discounted by Shri E. M. S. Namboodiripad who reiterated the faith of his Party in the Amritsar resolution which sought to achieve socialism through democratic means. This indicates that nobody in India favours change through violence. It is a different matter if people

TOWARDS NON-VIOLENT SOCIALISM

underground abide by violence. But change through law is the avowed objective of all parties—Congress, CPI, SSP, PSP, etc. Even the *Jan Sangh* does not want to maintain the *status-quo* and is anxious to remove exploitation and horrible inequalities stalking the country today. It claims to seek to establish Indian socialism according to the Indian genius and to follow the principle of equality propounded in the Gita. Thus all parties stand for change and socialism.

How I wish they could take some forward steps in the rural sphere. They must do something for the labourers or *bataidars* and thus show how far they are prepared to go ahead. I am sure that no revolutionary step can be launched through law by 1967. In fact, I visualise no change in the political scene of India even by 1972. It shall remain as it is today.

Facing The Chinese Challenge

Doubtless it shall be a very dangerous thing in the context of the Chinese danger. As Pandit Nehru repeatedly said, the main thing about that attack was not its military aspect but the ideological aggression implied therein. I do not mean to say that there is no military threat. It is there alright—in the Himalayas, in Nepal, in Bhutan, etc.—and is undoubtedly of a serious nature. But it is unthinkable that the Chinese would come on marching, defeating the Army here and then establishing their rule—even the Chinese cannot think on those lines. Nor is it possible for them to do so. But you cannot deny the effectiveness of the ideological

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invasion. And I do feel that there is no other way except Gramdan to face it.

Gramdan As The Pivot

From the above, you can easily see what Gramdan really is. I am sure that you will realise its importance; think over its role, and join shoulders together to work for it. For, if Gramdan succeeds it would help you in accomplishing so many other things, like Khadi, prohibition, removal of untouchability and also all programmes closely connected with the Sarvodaya movement. In fact, the Gramdan movement is a part and parcel of the Sarvodaya movement itself. In those times, Bapuji used to say that the spinning wheel was like the sun of the solar system called constructive work. In the present situation, I think that for the rural areas at any rate Gramdan is the sun. I believe that the accomplishment of the Gramdan revolution would have far-reaching impact on the market, on scarcity, on high prices, on poverty, on unemployment, on corruption and all. Gramdan is the central pivot of village life.

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